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Investigating the application of a Recommender System for Irish college courses

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A Dissertation

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Masters in Computer Science

Supervisor: Owen Conlan

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Declaration

I, the undersigned, declare that this work has not previously been submitted as an exercise for a degree at this, or any other University, and that unless otherwise stated, is my own work.

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March 20, 2026

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...ABSTRACT... **TODO**

Acknowledgments

TODO

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Contents

Abstract	ii
Acknowledgments	iii
Chapter 1 Introduction	1
1.1 Motivation	1
1.2 Research Question	4
1.3 Research Objectives	5
1.4 Overview	6
Chapter 2 Background Reading	7
2.1 The Leaving Certificate	7
2.2 NFQ Levels	8
2.3 The Central Applications Office	9
2.4 Entry Requirements	10
2.4.1 LC Points	10
2.4.2 LC Subject Requirements	11
2.4.3 Portfolios, Tests or Interviews	11
2.4.4 Alternative pathways to college	12
2.5 College course fees	12
2.6 Guidance Counsellors	13
2.7 Terminology differences with USA	13
2.8 Common types of Recommender Systems	14
2.9 Summary	14
Chapter 3 Literature Review	16
3.1 Fundamentals of college course choice	16
3.1.1 College course justifications	16
3.1.2 College justifications	17
3.1.3 External Influences	18

3.1.4	Theories of career & college course choice	23
3.1.5	Job & career satisfaction	28
3.1.6	Summary and synthesis of findings	31
3.2	Closely-Related Work	32
3.2.1	Simple filters	33
3.2.2	College course quizzes	35
3.2.3	College course Recommender Systems	37
3.3	Research Gap	38
3.4	Chapter Summary	41
Chapter 4	Initial Prototypes	42
4.1	Design Motivation	42
4.2	Datasets and initial challenges	43
4.3	Solution to introduced problems	44
4.4	Machine Learning model selection	45
4.5	Model Evaluation	45
4.6	Limitations of the approach	47
4.7	Chapter Summary	47
Chapter 5	Design	49
5.1	Interviews with Guidance Counsellors	49
5.1.1	Academic Interests	49
5.1.2	The RIASEC Model	50
5.1.3	Hobbies	51
5.1.4	The potential role of an RS in Guidance Counselling	51
5.2	User Information to Profile	52
5.2.1	Hobbies and Grades	54
5.2.2	Salary and Job Prospects	54
5.2.3	Meaning	54
5.2.4	Gender, Race/Ethnicity and Parent's Educational/Financial Back-ground	55
5.2.5	LC points, NFQ Levels and Colleges	56
5.2.6	Section Summary	56
Chapter 6	Implementation	58
6.1	Overview of the Solution	58
6.2	Component One	58
6.3	Summary	59

Chapter 7 Experiment Methodology	60
Chapter 8 Evaluation	61
8.1 Experiments	61
8.2 Results	62
8.3 Summary	63
Chapter 9 Conclusions & Future Work	64
9.1 Future Work	64
Bibliography	65

List of Tables

3.1	A comparison of the RS types used across closely-related works in literature.	38
3.2	Comparing features of all examined Closely-related work (Part 1)	39
3.3	Comparing features of all examined Closely-related work (Part 2)	39
6.1	Example user vector representation	59
6.2	Example college course vector representation	59
8.1	Objective Metrics	61
8.2	Statistical Significances	61
8.3	User-Perceived Metrics	62
8.4	Comparing features of all examined Closely-related work (Part 2)	62

List of Figures

2.1	A full list of LC exam grades and their translated LC points.	8
2.2	The 10-level NFQ system. Source: ¹	9
2.3	An example of an NFQ Level 8 CAO college course list.	10
3.1	Mean gender differences across different fields of study in Irish colleges. Red=Male, Blue=Female, Green=Non-binary or Prefer not to say. Source: Higher Education Authority (2024b).	21
3.2	Source: Hinrichs (2015).	22
3.3	Source: Hinrichs (2015).	22
3.4	Holland's RIASEC model. Source: ²	26
3.5	Herzberg's Two-factor theory. Source: ³	29
3.6	CareerPortal's college course filters.	33
3.7	CareerPortal's career sector filter.	33
3.8	CareerPortal's career interests filter.	33
3.9	A sample result of what users would see after applying some filters to a course search in CareersPortal.	34
3.10	Qualifax' college course category filter.	34
3.11	A sample result of what users would see after applying some filters to a course search in Qualifax.	34
3.12	A sample question provided on SuperProf's college major quiz.	36
3.13	A sample question provided on Anderson University's college major quiz. .	36
3.14	A sample results page after finishing the college major quiz on Anderson University.	36
3.15	A sample results page after finishing the college major quiz on SuperProf. .	36
4.1	An example of a question given on the OpenPsychometrics RIASEC quiz. .	43
4.2	A Confusion Matrix for Recall scores on the HGBC model.	46

¹<https://www.courses.ie/national-framework-qualifications-nfq-explained>

²<https://workforce.org/san-diego-jobs/my-next-move-2/riasec/>

³<https://www.simplypsychology.org/herzbergs-two-factor-theory.html>

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Motivation

This section describes the context behind known problems in the research domain and provides some background knowledge. In light of these established problems, a technology is introduced, one that could be appropriately applied to this domain. The applicability of the proposed solution is also discussed, all relevant issues in describing the research motivation behind this dissertation.

According to Higher Education Authority (2024b), over 48,000 Irish secondary school students progressed to college after graduation in 2024. The individuals who have considered progressing to college have all been posed with the question: *What college course should I study?* This is a daunting question for many reasons. The majority of secondary school students are faced with making this decision at 16-19 years old, an age with limited life experience and knowledge about the world. In Smyth et al. (2011), Irish students were reported to experience significantly increasing levels of stress in their final year of secondary school, complicating this decision further. This decision also comes with many personally confronting questions, which may include: *“What do I want to do with the rest of my life?”* and *“What do I love doing?”*, among many others. Moreover, an individual may choose a college course they will later regret. For instance, in Higher Education Authority (2018), 31% of recent Irish college graduates reported they were not likely to study their college course again, and in Roese and Summerville (2005), vocational mismatch is said to be a frequent regret for many Americans, adding more weight to this crucial life decision.

Choosing a college course is not only a challenging decision to wrestle with as an individual. Individuals are shown to be influenced by a multitude of external factors when

choosing their college course. For instance in Aydin (2015); Leighton and Speer (2023), parents are shown to be one of the most influential factors of an individual's college course choice. Aydin (2015); Dickson (2010) have also shown that an individual's race/ethnicity, and their parent's educational and financial background are among the most prominent societal influences of an individual's college course choice, adding complexity to a decision that is already challenging.

To assist students in this difficult decision, it is worth introducing the role of a Guidance Counsellor (GC). GC's are trained professional in Irish secondary schools, primarily known for assisting students in their career prospects after graduation. It is worth noting that the role of a GC extends well beyond vocational support - according to Institute of Guidance Counsellors (2016), GC's are also trained to provide educational, personal and social support. In this context, it is worth introducing the Institute of Guidance Counsellors (IGC)¹, the professional body for GC's in Ireland. In a report by the Institute of Guidance Counsellors (2022), mental health issues were more commonly encountered by GC's compared to career decision-making issues², marking the first time that career decision-making issues were not the most commonly encountered issue by GC's since 2019. In the IGC's 2024-2027 strategic plan outlined in Institute of Guidance Counsellors (2024b), the IGC noted this stronger prevalence of mental health issues compared to career decision-making issues, signalling a shift in priorities for GC's across Irish secondary schools: vocational support may not be the most important aspect of a GC's role going forward.

We can shift our focus to the more technical side of things. A Recommender System (RS) is a technology that recommend items to a user. Well-known examples of RS's include Netflix³ recommending films to their customers, or Amazon⁴ suggesting products to their customers. One of the earliest known RS's was *Tapestry* in Goldberg et al. (1992), a system that made tailored mailing list recommendations to its users. Around this time, the field of RS's received considerable interest as e-commerce websites could increase their revenue if they suggested more personalised products to their users. As discussed in Schafer et al. (1999), Amazon and Netflix are the most notable adopters of RS's in order to increase company revenue.

¹<https://igc.ie/>

²In Institute of Guidance Counsellors (2024a), career decision-making issues did surpass mental health issues as the most commonly encountered issue for GC's, however, both are pressing issues.

³<https://www.netflix.com/>

⁴<https://www.amazon.com/>

As previously explained, an RS recommends *items* to a *user*. However, we can re-conceptualize an RS in the context of college courses: *college courses* can take the place of *items*, and a *student* can take the place of a *user*. Given the established difficulty and influences of an individual's college course choice, the shifting priorities of GC's towards student's mental health as opposed to career-making decisions, and a technology that could be appropriately applied to this domain, an exciting opportunity presents itself: A Recommender System for Irish College Courses.

A technology, such as an RS, could aid an individual in navigating a difficult decision-making process. For instance, there are over 45 higher education institutes in Ireland offering a total of over 1700 courses⁵, representing a huge set of choice to the individual. An advantage of a personalised RS is to provide a user with a much smaller list of relevant recommendations. Long et al. (2025) demonstrated that smaller recommendation sets are often equally as effective as larger recommendations sets, suggesting that a much narrower set of personalised college course recommendations could be effective in this space.

For the 2026/2027 academic year, 52⁶ new higher education courses were introduced in Ireland. Moreover, as discussed in Section 2.4.1, the requirements for Irish higher education courses change every year as a reflection of demand and changing priorities. This introduces administrative strain on GC's, making it difficult to have up-to-date awareness on the newest courses and current course entry requirements. A technology, such as an RS, can be automated to hold the latest college course information and utilise this information in recommending college courses that a human GC may not even be aware of, posing a potential advantage of an RS in this domain.

In summary, this section introduced the numerous difficulties posed to an individual in choosing a suitable college course. These difficulties include the sheer weight of this decision, and the external factors that influence an individual's college course decision. We then discussed the shifting priorities of GC's from vocational to personal support, and introduced a technology which could be applicable to this domain - a Recommender System. A discussion was given into the ways in which a college course RS could alleviate this problem for both students and GC's, ultimately describing the motivation behind this research.

⁵Higher education colleges and courses can be found here: <https://careersportal.ie/>

⁶See footnote See https://careersportal.ie/courses/coursefinder?types_in=2 for new courses

1.2 Research Question

TODO - this RQ has gone through quite a few iterations, read the above and make sure enough context is provided! **TODO** - ctrl f for "Research question" and "RQ" and ensure the latest iteration is being referenced!

In light of the motivation behind this research, the Research Question for this dissertation can be formulated: *"Can a Recommender System assist an Irish student in exploring college courses they would consider studying?"*

In this Research Question, the meaning of "assist" is intentionally broad, and we can further understand the meaning of "assist" by exploring the three qualities of an effective RS, as outlined in Aggarwal et al. (2016), the leading textbook on RS's:

According to Aggarwal, the recommendations should be **Relevant** to the user's preferences. In this context, an effective RS would recommend college courses the user would consider studying based off their profiled preferences. For example, it would generally not make sense to recommend healthcare courses to a student that has demonstrated no interest in healthcare. In context to our Research Question, an RS with relevant recommendations would assist a student by recommending college courses they would consider studying.

The recommendations should be **Diverse** and avoid being uniform in a particular category. For example, an effective RS would not suggest 20 different Computer Science courses to a user, even if the user has demonstrated a strong interest in computers. If we revisit the Research Question, we want an RS that assists a student's college course **exploration**, and by suggesting college courses across a diverse range of the user's preferences, the RS would assist the user in discovering college courses they would consider studying.

A user may receive recommendations that are **relevant** to their preferences and **diverse** across their interests, however the user may already have an awareness of these recommendations. For example, a student may receive recommendations in Biology and Engineering, but they may have already considered studying these college courses previously. As a result, the user does not actually gain any new information after interacting with the RS. The quality that separates a good RS from a great one is **Serendipity**. These are recommendations that are genuinely unexpected but incredibly relevant. The RS demonstrates a deep knowledge of the user, providing the user with relevant recom-

recommendations that they were genuinely unaware of. Continuing our example, a serendipitous recommendation to this user might be Biomedical Engineering, merging both of the user’s interests in an unexpected but useful way, providing the user with a college course they were genuinely unaware of, and the user may now be considering studying the college course after interacting with the RS. This would be incredibly effective in assisting the user with their college course exploration, as outlined in the Research Question.

Serendipity is the **gold standard** for RS’s. However, it is very challenging to consistently produce serendipitous recommendations, because by their nature the recommendations are “high risk, high reward”. RS’s are often faced with the dilemma between producing “safe” recommendations that are likely relevant but uninteresting, or more “adventurous” recommendations that are serendipitous or unsatisfactory. This is a well-known tradeoff in the field of RS’s, and it is the price you pay for attempting to achieve the gold standard in RS’s: serendipity.

In summary, the Research Question for this dissertation is: *“Can a Recommender System assist an Irish student in exploring college courses they would consider studying?”*, and we propose that an RS that provides **relevant**, **diverse** and **serendipitous** recommendations would assist an Irish student in exploring college courses they would consider studying.

1.3 Research Objectives

todo - lowkey could revise these after writing everything! With the motivation and research question formulated, the research objectives for this dissertation are outlined below:

1. Conduct thorough background research in answering the question: *“What college course should people study?”*
2. Identify the relevant information to question a user in order to make suitable college course recommendations.
3. Create an Irish college course RS with statistically significant improvements compared to a baseline college course RS.
4. Analyse user evaluation metrics gathered from a conducted experiment.
5. Explore the qualities that would make an effective college course RS. **mmm lowkey maybe not good ngl**

1.4 Overview

In this section, an overview of this dissertation's chapters are provided.

- Chapter 2- Background Reading. This chapter describes the necessary background knowledge to understand the Irish secondary school and college admission system.
- Chapter 3 - Literature Review. This chapter provides the reader with a solid understanding of the nuances behind an individual's college course choice. There will be explorations into an individual's motivations behind choosing a college course, the external influences of an individual's college course choice, and the relevant information to question a user in order to make suitable college course recommendations, among other relevant discussions. As well as this, there will be an exploration into existing implementations of college course RS's, both in literature and real-world products. This includes a discussion into their successes and limitations.
- Chapter 4 - Initial Prototypes. **TODO**.
- Chapter 5 - Design. **TODO**
- Chapter 6 - Implementation. **TODO**
- Chapter 7 - Experiment Methodology. This chapter describes the experiment methodology in which the RS was tested with human participants.
- Chapter 8 - Evaluation. This chapter provides an objective analysis of the experiment evaluation metrics, and provides a qualitative analysis of verbal feedback gathered from the experiment.
- Chapter 9 - Conclusions & Future Work. **TODO**

Chapter 2

Background Reading

As mentioned in Chapter 1, this dissertation specifically focuses on a college course RS in the context of the Irish secondary school and college system. Grading systems and college admission systems often differ between countries, so this chapter seeks to provide essential background knowledge behind the Irish secondary school and the college admission system. There will be an explanation of the Leaving Certificate - the final Irish secondary school exam - the National Framework of Qualifications, a categorisation of Irish college courses, and the Central Applications Office, the primary college admission system in Ireland. As well as this, there will be a description of Irish college entry requirements, the fees and scholarships of undergraduate Irish college courses, and a greater explanation of the role of a GC in Irish secondary schools. Upon completion of the chapter, the reader should be familiar with the workings of the Irish secondary school and college admission system.

2.1 The Leaving Certificate

The Leaving Certificate (LC) is the final examination taken by the majority of secondary school students in Ireland. Instead of taking the LC, students can take the Leaving Certificate Applied (LCA) which is a more practical alternative to the LC. Students who take the LCA cannot directly enter higher education institutes; they commonly go for direct employment, apprenticeships or enter further education institutes. For the sake of narrowing scope, apprenticeships and further education courses are considered beyond the scope of this RS. The RS proposed in this dissertation will only recommend higher education college courses in Ireland.

A student's overall performance in the LC is measured in terms of points, a number that ranges between 0 and 625, where 625 is the maximum achievable points. A student

chooses to be examined in each subject at increasing levels of difficulty, known as Higher Level (HL), Ordinary Level (OL) or Foundation Level (FL) ¹. A student receives a grade depending on the level and mark they achieve in the subject. For example, a student that gets a mark of 91% in the HL LC English exam receives a H1 grade, for which they receive 100 points, and a student that gets a mark of 64% in their OL LC Geography exam receives an O4 grade, for which they receive 28 points. For a full list of LC exam grades and their translated LC points, see Figure 2.1 below. A student is examined in a minimum of 6 subjects, and their overall LC points is an accumulation of the points received in each examined subject.

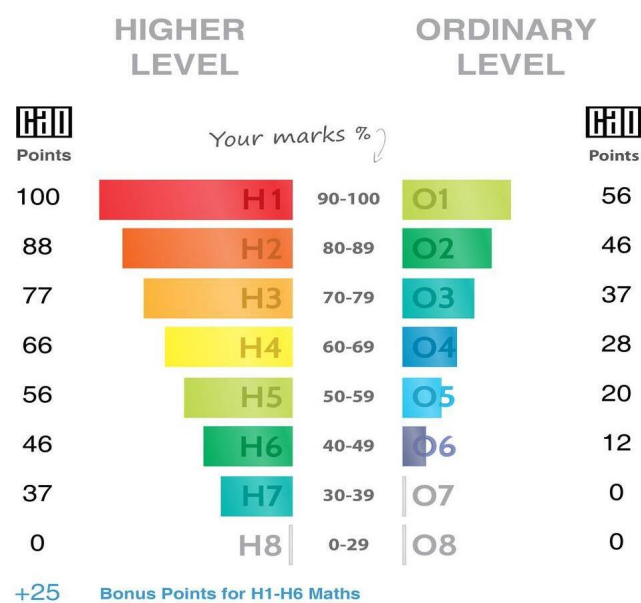


Figure 2.1: A full list of LC exam grades and their translated LC points.

2.2 NFQ Levels

The Irish National Framework of Qualifications (NFQ) ² is a system that describes all education qualifications in Ireland. It is a 10-level system, where 1 is the lowest and 10 is the highest (doctorate degree). For instance, the LC is classed as NFQ Level 5. The NFQ levels that are relevant to this dissertation are NFQ Level 6 (Advanced or Higher Certificate), NFQ Level 7 (Ordinary Bachelors degree), NFQ Level 8 (Honours Bachelor degree) and NFQ Level 9 (Masters degree). A full graphic of the 10 NFQ levels are shown below in figure 2.2.

¹Foundation Level is only offered for the LC Irish and Mathematics subjects.

²<https://www.qqi.ie/what-we-do/the-qualifications-system/national-framework-of-qualifications>

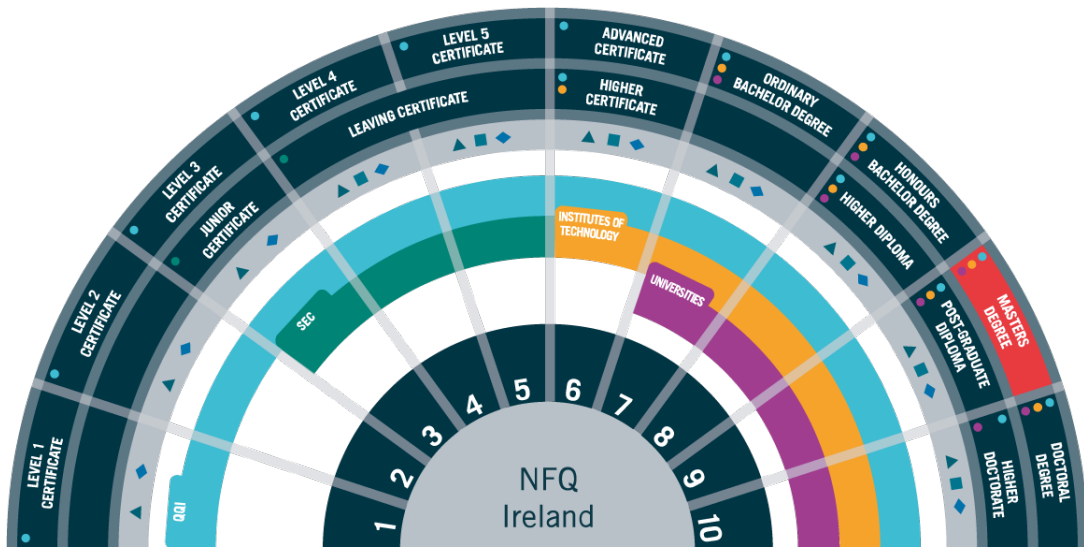


Figure 2.2: The 10-level NFQ system. Source: ³

2.3 The Central Applications Office

Rather than going to the colleges directly to apply for a specific college course, in Ireland all college applications are done through the Central Applications Office (CAO) ⁴, the centralised college admissions system in Ireland. For reference, there were over 83,000 applications to the CAO in 2025 according to Central Applications Office (2025). As part of a CAO application, students are encouraged to create two numbered lists, each with up to 10 college courses. One of these numbered lists are for NFQ Level 8 college courses, and the other list is for NFQ Level 6 and 7 college courses. These college courses are ordered by the student's preference of study - for instance, the student's number one choice would be the course they want to study the most, and their number ten choice is the course they want to study the least out of this list. An example of this list is given below in 2.3

⁴<https://www.cao.ie/>

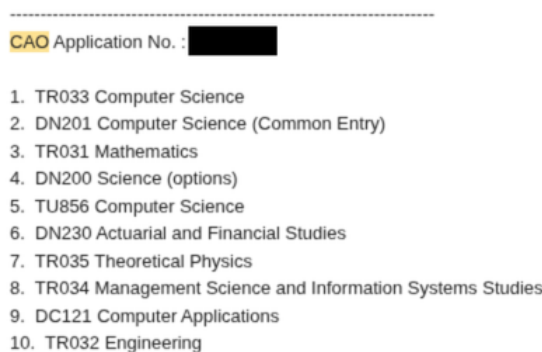


Figure 2.3: An example of an NFQ Level 8 CAO college course list.

The preference ranking of a student’s CAO application courses is relevant here. For example, if a student receives an offer for a course that is ranked first in their list, they will not receive offers for courses below this preference, even if they satisfy the course’s entry requirements. Entry requirements will be explained in section 2.4.

2.4 Entry Requirements

Entry requirements for colleges differ by country, and in this section the entry requirements for Irish college courses are described.

2.4.1 LC Points

The primary entry requirement for most college courses in Ireland is LC points. For example, the Computer Science (CS) course in Trinity College Dublin (TCD) has a minimum entry requirement of 533 points ⁵, meaning that a student must achieve 533 points or higher in their LC to be considered admission into the course. A course’s LC points is the points of the student who was last admitted to the course in the previous academic year. For example, let’s suppose that in 2025, 150 people were admitted into CS in TCD. Out of all these 150 students, the student with the lowest LC points was 533, meaning the course has a minimum entry requirement of 533 LC points. As a result, the LC points associated with a course are not fixed and fluctuate every year. LC points are commonly misunderstood as reflecting the difficulty of a course, however, it would be more accurate to say that the LC points reflect the *demand* of a course.

⁵533 points as of 2025, see: <https://www.tcd.ie/courses/undergraduate/courses/computer-science/>

There are a handful of ways in which a student can achieve additional LC points. For example, A student will receive an extra 25 points if they achieve a passing ($\geq 40\%$) grade in the HL Mathematics exam. As well as this, if a student is takes their LC exams in the Irish language, they can receive up to 10% in bonus marks in each of their LC exams ⁶.

2.4.2 LC Subject Requirements

Many Irish college courses have grade requirements for specific subjects to allow admission into the course. In most cases, the subjects are relevant to the course and the college seeks knowledge in that subject. For example, CS in TCD has a minimum entry requirement of a H4 (60-69% in HL) in Mathematics to be considered for admission into the course.

In Ireland, students are obligated to take the LC English, Mathematics and Irish ⁷ exams, and they choose a minimum of four additional subjects to take exams in. The student makes their subject choices in fifth year, which is the penultimate year in Irish secondary schools. Due to the differing subject entry requirements by college courses, some students may be unable to take certain courses simply because they have not taken the relevant subject. For example, if a student has not taken two science ⁸ subjects, they are unable to be admitted into Medicine ⁹, meaning that a student's college course options are already limited by the subject choices they made in fifth year, almost two years before they finalise their CAO college course list.

In addition to specific college courses requiring a minimum grade in particular subjects, some subjects are required to be admitted into the college itself. For example, all Royal College of Surgeons in Ireland courses ¹⁰ require a third language ¹¹.

2.4.3 Portfolios, Tests or Interviews

In a majority of cases, if a student satisfies the minimum entry requirements for a course with their LC points and subject grades, the student is admitted into the course. However, some Irish college courses have additional entry requirements. For instance, some courses may require the student to be examined in a test outside of the Leaving Cer-

⁶for exact bonus marks in answering the LC in the Irish language, see: <https://www.citizensinformation.ie/en/education/state-examinations/leaving-certificate/>

⁷Some students may qualify for an exemption from Irish if they satisfy certain requirements.

⁸LC Physics, Chemistry, Physics/Chemistry, Biology and Agricultural Science.

⁹Subject requirements for TCD Medicine as of 2026: <https://www.tcd.ie/courses/undergraduate/courses/medicine/>

¹⁰As of 2026, see: <https://www.rcsi.com/dublin/undergraduate/medicine/entry-requirements>

¹¹Languages other than English and Irish, for example: German, Spanish, Italian, etc.

tificate. For example, all Medicine courses in Ireland require their applicants to sit the Health Professions Admissions Test (HPAT) ¹². Some college courses may also require a portfolio submission, or for the student to undertake an interview. For example, the Architecture course in Technological University Dublin ¹³ requires the student to submit an additional portfolio showcasing the student's competence in sketching, painting, etc., as well as an interview demonstrating their interest in the course. Some courses may also require students to go through Garda Vetting ¹⁴, a background check for individuals working with children or vulnerable adults, an example of this includes General Nursing in TCD ¹⁵.

In the case of Portfolios and Tests, the students score in these are added to their total LC points. For example, if a student achieves 550 LC points and a score of 200 in the HPAT, their combined LC points is 750 only when the student is applying for courses that require the HPAT. This explains why some courses may have a minimum requirement of 732 LC points, despite 625 being the maximum achievable LC points.

2.4.4 Alternative pathways to college

In Ireland, there are multiple alternative pathways to college, and in this subsection there will be an explanation of the different access routes. Disability Access Route to Education (DARE) ¹⁶ is a scheme offering college courses at reduced LC points for students with disabilities. Higher Education Access Route (HEAR) ¹⁷ is a scheme offering college courses at reduced LC points and financial aid for students from underrepresented economic or social backgrounds. Students starting college over the age of 23 are categorised as Mature students ¹⁸, and their entry into college is not based on LC points, but instead a mature student's entry is based on their educational background, work history and other factors.

2.5 College course fees

In this subsection, there will be an explanation of undergraduate college course fees in Ireland. In Ireland, the majority of undergraduate college courses are publicly funded through the Irish government. As of 2026, the majority of undergraduate college course

¹²<https://hpat-ireland.acer.org/>

¹³<https://www.tudublin.ie/study/undergraduate/courses/architecture-tu832/>

¹⁴<https://vetting.garda.ie/>

¹⁵<https://www.tcd.ie/courses/undergraduate/courses/nursing---general-nursing/>

¹⁶<https://accesscollege.ie/dare/what-is-dare/>

¹⁷<https://accesscollege.ie/hear/what-is-hear/>

¹⁸<https://www.citizensinformation.ie/en/education/third-level-education/applying-to-college/third-level-courses-for-mature-students/>

fees for Irish students cost €2,500 annually ¹⁹. In this context, it is worth introducing the Student Universal Support Ireland (SUSI) ²⁰, Ireland’s national awarding authority for college grants. If the combined household income of a student lies under different thresholds ²¹, the student may qualify for SUSI grants that cover their college course fees and living expenses, giving college opportunities to students from less affluent backgrounds in Ireland.

2.6 Guidance Counsellors

The role of a Guidance Counsellor (GC) has already been described in Section 1.1, however, this section provides additional background information regarding the role of a GC in Irish secondary schools. As legally mandated in Irish Statute Book (1998), every Irish secondary school student has access to a GC to assist them in their educational and career choices. That being said, all GC’s do not spend all of their time on guidance counselling. According to Institute of Guidance Counsellors (2024a), 43.6% of GC’s are exclusively involved in guidance counselling as part of their role in the school, whereas the other 56.4% combine guidance counselling with other duties, such as subject teaching and school administrative roles.

2.7 Terminology differences with USA

In Ireland, a “college course” defines the collection of college classes taken over the duration of the student’s degree. An example of a college course in Ireland is Computer Science at Trinity College Dublin, encompassing 48 classes taken over the four year degree ²². In the United States of America (USA), a “college course” refers to a specific class at college, whereas a “college major” is the equivalent terminology for what is defined as a “college course” in Ireland. For example, following the terminology in the USA, you would take a Computer Programming course as part of your Computer Science major. For the purposes of clarity, in this dissertation, the term “college course” will refer to the Irish definition of a “college course”. As a result, the terms “college course” and

¹⁹For instance, see TCD’s undergraduate fees: <https://www.tcd.ie/courses/undergraduate/fees/>

²⁰<https://www.susi.ie/>

²¹for specific circumstances and thresholds, see <https://www.susi.ie/eligibility-criteria/income/full-time-undergraduate-income-thresholds-and-grant-award-rates/>

²²<https://www.tcd.ie/courses/undergraduate/courses/computer-science/>

“college major” are seen as equivalents and will be used interchangeably throughout this dissertation.

2.8 Common types of Recommender Systems

As mentioned in Chapter 1, a Recommender System (RS) is a technology that recommends items to users. There are many different **types** of RS’s, and in this section we will describe three types of RS’s that are relevant to this dissertation. It is worth noting we will not describe their advantages or limitations, instead a straightforward definition will be provided. We will follow the definitions as described in Aggarwal et al. (2016).

A **Content-Based Filtering** (CBF) RS uses information explicitly provided by the user in order to make recommendations. For example, a CBF RS would recommend Biology to a user because they explicitly expressed interest in the biological sciences.

A **Collaborative Filtering** (CF) RS requires the information about *other* users who have also interacted with the RS. A CF RS recommends items to a user that other similar users also liked. For example, a CF RS would recommend Computer Science to a user, because other users with similar interests also liked Computer Science.

A **Knowledge-Based Filtering** (KBF) RS is much more direct and asks the user for explicit specifications, recommending items to users that fit these specifications. For example, a user may explicitly specify they want Business courses in Dublin, and then the user may be recommended Commerce in University College Dublin.

A **Hybrid** RS combines multiple types of RS’s into one. For example, a Hybrid RS may utilise CBF and KBF approaches in generating recommendations. For example, a user may be asked to explicitly specify the colleges they want to study at (KBF), and then be recommended college courses based on their profiled preferences (CBF).

2.9 Summary

In summary, this chapter provided the reader with knowledge surrounding the workings of the Irish secondary school and college admissions system. In particular, the LC and LC points system was explained, including the grading system and the way in which subjects are examined at different levels - for example, Higher Level or Ordinary Level. The reader was introduced to the workings of NFQ Levels and the CAO system, developing

an understanding into the Irish college admission system. In addition to this, the varying entry requirements into specific courses or colleges were explained. Moreover, the role of GC's were explained in greater detail and this was followed up with a discussion of undergraduate college course fees in Ireland. With this chapter complete, we are better equipped with an understanding behind the Irish secondary school and college admission system.

Chapter 3

Literature Review

As part of this chapter, there will be a review of the literature regarding the fundamentals of college course choice. Ultimately, this section seeks to provide insights to the question: “*What college course should people study?*” As we will discover, the question is incredibly multi-faceted with no straightforward answers. After a thorough review of the fundamentals of college course choice, there will be an examination into closely-related works, including both academic works and real-world products. This will equip us with the information to clearly define the research gap addressed by this research.

3.1 Fundamentals of college course choice

This section will explore the fundamentals of college course choice, and this exploration will follow a narrative as follows. Firstly, we will explore *why* students choose their college and college course by examining the common justifications in their decision. Afterwards, we will examine the external influences, or the *how*, of their college and college course choice, including parent’s educational background, gender and others. This equips us with an insight as to *how* and *why* students choose their college course, and the next logical question to ask is: “*So, what college course should people study?*” We will turn our attention to academic literature and popular sentiment in answering this question. Finally, after understanding the *how*, the *why* and the *should* of college course choice, we will examine the features of job and career satisfaction and reverse-engineer these insights to help us answer the all-elusive question: “*What college course should people study?*”

3.1.1 College course justifications

As established in Chapter 1, choosing a college course is a major life decision. As a result, we can assume that students choose a particular college course for a set of reasons. The

reasons, or justifications, that students provide for choosing their college course choice will be explored in this subsection.

According to Matthews et al. (2024); Gillis and Ryberg (2021); Mullen (2011), the most common and prominent justifications students cited when choosing their college course can be broadly categorised as: *interest* in the subject area, a sense of *meaning*, *satisfying parent's desires*, *work/life balance*, and *salary expectations* and *job prospects* after graduation. This is by no means an exhaustive list, however, it does cover the most prominent justifications provided by students when justifying their college course choice.

These justifications were all commonly cited across genders and race/ethnicity, however, there were different priorities across gender and race/ethnicity. For instance, Gillis and Ryberg (2021) found that on average, men are more likely to be career-oriented when choosing their college course compared to women, whereas in Matthews et al. (2024), men were found to be more likely to cite *salary expectations* and *job prospects* as their justifications for choosing their college course. Moreover, Goyette and Mullen (2006) found that Asians were more likely to prioritise *salary expectations* in their college course choice, compared to other races/ethnicities. The above examples showcase the different priorities of justifications for college course choice across race/ethnicity and gender. Despite this difference, the papers still conclude that all the above justifications are relevant across the differing genders and races/ethnicities. In other words, despite the findings that, for example, Asians were more likely to prioritise *salary expectations* after graduation, does not imply Asians do not also value other motivations in choosing their college course, such as *interest or passion* in the subject.

3.1.2 College justifications

Choosing a college course is one decision, but a separate and closely related decision is choosing the college itself. For example, a student may settle on studying Computer Science, but the next question to ask is: *Where do I study Computer Science?* In this subsection, there will be an examination into a student's justifications in choosing their college.

Aydin (2015); College MatchPoint (2018); Baharun (2010) have found that students provide a variety of justifications for their college choice, the most prominent justifications include: *prestige or reputation* of the college, *location* or *practicality*, *friends* attending

the college, *departments* or *academic staff*, *family members* being college alumni, and particular *sports clubs* or *societies*. Once again, this is by no means an exhaustive list, however, it does cover the most prominent justifications of students' college choice.

That being said, there seem to be cultural differences in priorities of college choice justifications. For instance, in Baharun (2010), a study of Malaysian college students, the college's *reputation* was the most important justification in college choice, whereas in Telli Yamamoto (2006), a study of Turkish college students, *departments* and *academic staff* were the most important justification in college choice. While we can clearly observe cultural differences in the most important justifications for college choice, a similar point stands: just because Malaysian students, for example, value college *reputation* as the most important justification in college choice, does not imply Malaysian students do not value other aspects to the college when justifying their college decision, as can be found in Baharun (2010).

3.1.3 External Influences

In subsections 3.1.1 and 3.1.2, we examined the justifications students provided in relation to their college and college course choice. However, in this subsection we will discover that a student does not make this decision in a vacuum. In fact, a student's college and college course choice is shown to be influenced by a variety of external influences. For instance, we will examine the influence of a parent's educational and financial background on a student's college and college course choice. In addition to this, we will explore the influence of gender, race and ethnicity on college course choice. All of the aforementioned influences are being classed under the umbrella term "External Influences" for the sake of clarity.

Parent's educational and financial background

In this discussion, we will explore the influence of a parent's educational and financial background on a student's college and college course choice. According to Leighton and Speer (2023), there is a strong correlation between a student's college course choice and their parent's educational background. According to their findings, students with more educated parents will lean towards college courses with lower early-career earnings, but with faster growth towards higher earnings later in their career. This is likely because students with stronger financial safety nets can afford to pursue college courses with lower

early-career earnings in the short-term, and await higher earnings later on in their career. On the other hand, according to Leighton and Speer (2023), students with less educated parents will lean towards college courses with more defined career paths and higher early-career earnings. This is likely because students with weaker financial safety nets can not afford to pursue college courses with lower early-career earnings in the same way students with stronger financial safety nets can. As a result, students with less educated parents prioritise “safer” college courses with more defined career paths that yield higher early-career earnings. There are analogous findings in Mullen (2011): working-class parents generally encourage their children to attend college courses that directly prepare them for careers, whereas middle class parents generally encourage college courses where their children can explore their interests. Moreover, Mullen et al. (2003) has shown that the parental educational background of a student has a strong correlation with the student’s attendance in a postgraduate degree program. The findings above all give credence to the idea that an individual’s college course choice is strongly influenced by both their parent’s educational and financial backgrounds.

Interestingly, according to Leighton and Speer (2023), they failed to find a strong correlation between the parental income of a student and their college course choice. However, they did find a strong correlation between the parental income of a student and the college they study at. That being said, it is worth mentioning this study was conducted on data obtained from the United States Census Bureau 2009-2018 survey¹. According to College Board (2025), college undergraduate fees in the USA can range from \$4,150 - \$45,000 annually, resulting in a much larger financial barrier to entry for American students from less affluent backgrounds. This would explain the strong correlation between parental income and the student’s college choice in the USA.

When it comes to Ireland, as discussed in section 2.5, the majority of Irish undergraduate college courses are priced at €2,500 annually, a much more affordable price for undergraduate education compared to the USA. This price not only lowers the financial barrier of entry for Irish students from less affluent backgrounds, but there are also higher education grants² for Irish students with income underneath a certain threshold, allowing Irish students from less affluent backgrounds to attend college. Due to the lower financial barrier of entry for Irish undergraduate students in comparison to undergraduate students in the USA, the author would argue that the finding, specifically in Leighton and Speer (2023) that parental income is correlated with a student’s college choice, would not be

¹<https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs>

²<https://www.susi.ie/>

applied so strongly to the Irish context given the lower financial barrier to entry in Ireland.

That being said, it would be ignorant to assume that parental income is not an influence on college choice for Irish students. For example, according to the QS World University Rankings 2026³, the two top-ranked universities in Ireland are in Dublin. According to O'Connor (2025), it is estimated to cost a student an additional €4,000 - €11,000 every year to live away from home in Dublin, compared to someone who lives in Dublin at a family home, clearly demonstrating a limitation imposed on Irish students who cannot afford that kind of money. As a result, we have clearly demonstrated that an Irish student's financial background limits their college choice, which naturally has an influence on their college choice.

Gender

In this discussion we will explore the influence of gender on college course choice. Figure 3.1 visualises the proportional difference of gender across different fields of study in Irish colleges. As is clearly observable, many fields of study are not equal in gender. To give some extreme examples of college course participation in Ireland, according to Higher Education Authority (2024b), Fisheries has 100% male participation, and Pre-school education has 97% female participation, demonstrating the large gaps in gender proportions across different fields of study in Ireland.

³<https://www.topuniversities.com/world-university-rankings?countries=ie>

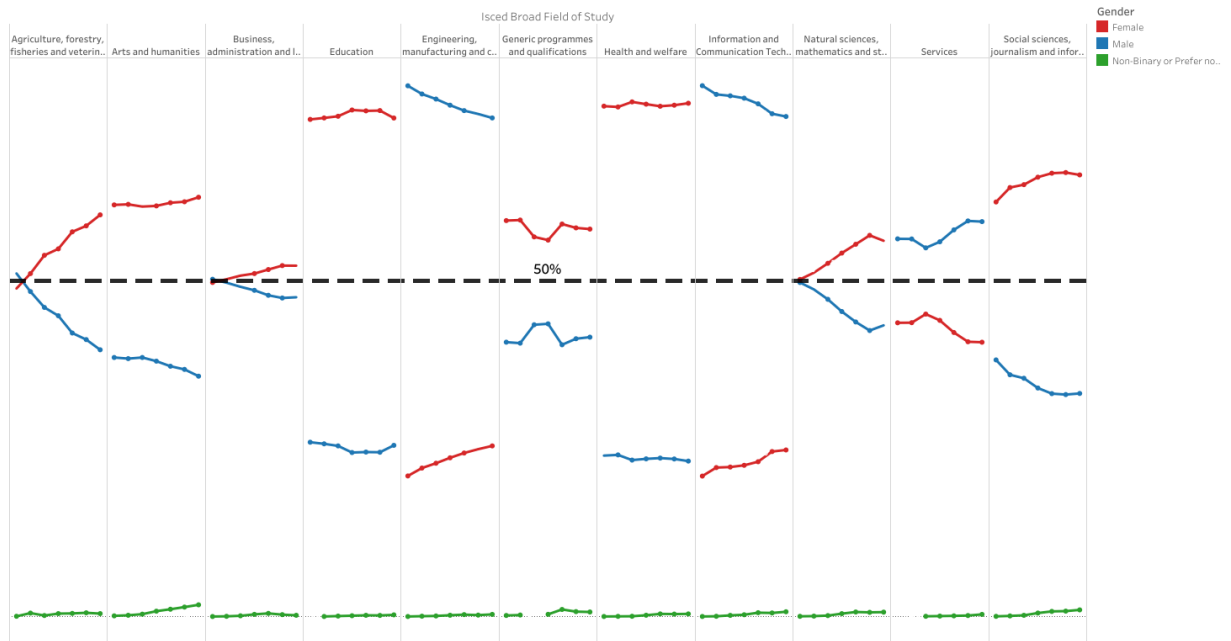


Figure 3.1: Mean gender differences across different fields of study in Irish colleges. Red=Male, Blue=Female, Green=Non-binary or Prefer not to say. Source: Higher Education Authority (2024b).

The above Figure 3.1 and aforementioned statistics clearly demonstrate gender differences across different fields of study, and the next question to ask is: “what are the negative impacts, if any, of studying a college course that features a strong proportion of one gender?” Slattery et al. (2023) conducted a qualitative study on 21 female students studying either Mathematics (66% male), Physics (68% male), Computer Science (74% male) or Engineering (71% male) in Ireland - parenthesised data is from Higher Education Authority (2024b). Slattery et al. (2023) found that during their studies, females felt under-valued by their male peers, which negatively impacted their self-beliefs and interest in the course subject matter. In addition to this, they found that females suffered more pressure to perform, and were less likely to engage in the learning environment, showcasing an overall negative experience for females in male-dominated fields of study.

Experiences of isolation and lack of belonging due to gender differences, such as the example given above, are well-known. To provide an example, in I Wish (2025), a survey of Irish secondary school girl’s attitudes towards Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM), 65% of girls reported that “Poor gender equality in STEM careers” is a barrier to continuing their studies in STEM. This is quite striking considering that girls express these viewpoints before they even begin studying in these STEM-related fields. These feelings act as deterrents for girls considering studying in STEM, influencing

their college course choice solely on their gender.

A specific example of poor gender equality in STEM was provided in this discussion, however it demonstrates the overall point that gender has a strong influence on college course choice of students in Ireland.

Race and Ethnicity

In this discussion, we will explore the influence of race and ethnicity on college course choice. The author was unable to find statistics for racial or ethnic differences by college course study in Ireland, so statistics from Hinrichs (2015) are used, which was collected from the National Center for Education Statistics in the US Department of Education.

According to analysis from Hinrichs, there are a handful of striking racial or ethnic differences by college course choice. For example, as shown in Figure 3.2, 31% of Asian students study a STEM-related college course, a much higher proportion compared to 11% black, 13% hispanic and 15% white students. An additional example of racial or ethnic differences by college course choice can be found in Figure 3.3, which examines the proportion of race and ethnicity in Public Administration and Social Service: nearly 4% of black students study in this field, a relatively large difference compared to under 1% for Asian, 2.5% hispanic and 1.5% white students studying in this field.

Percentage of Bachelor's Degree Recipients Majoring in STEM Subjects

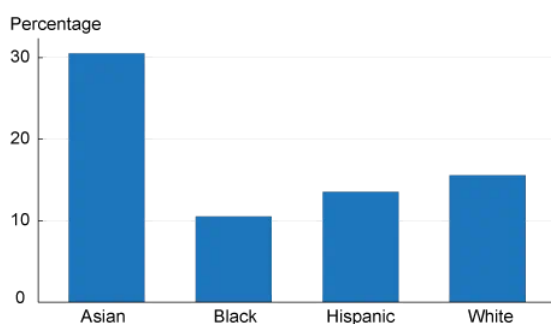


Figure 3.2: Source: Hinrichs (2015).

Percentage of Bachelor's Degree Recipients Majoring in Public Administration and Social Service Professions Subjects

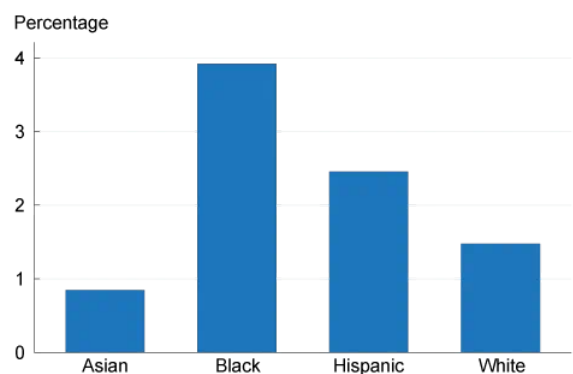


Figure 3.3: Source: Hinrichs (2015).

Further to this analysis, we can examine the work conducted by Dickson (2010), a study performed on administrative data from three Texas Universities (n=127,330). Similar proportions of findings were reported, for example Dickson found that 37% of

Science-related college course students were Asian, with 26% white, 24% black and 23% hispanic students being the other prominent racial/ethnic groups. As to why this may be the case, Xie and Goyette (2003) argues that Asian-Americans prioritise “objective” credentials and “hard” skills, which are more difficult to discriminate against in job interviews that are more focused on technical ability, as opposed to job interviews focusing more on “soft” skills. This poses a potential explanation for the relatively high proportion of Asians in Science-related college courses compared to other racial/ethnic groups.

Overall, the findings of Hinrichs (2015) and Dickson (2010) demonstrate the differing proportions of race or ethnicity across college course choices in the USA. In this discussion, there was particular focus on the high proportion of Asians in Science-related college courses, for which Xie and Goyette (2003) provided a potential explanation. More generally, this demonstrates the undeniable influence of race and ethnicity on a student’s college course choice.

Summary of External Influences

In this subsection, there was an exploration into the external influences of a student’s college and college course choice. A student’s college course choice is clearly influenced by their personal preferences towards the college and college course choice, as outlined in subsections 3.1.1 and 3.1.2 respectively. That being said, to assume a student’s college choice is influenced solely on their personal preferences would be ignorant when one examines the data. In this subsection, there was a discussion into the influence of parent’s educational and financial background on a student’s college and college course choice. As well as this, there was a discussion on the undeniable influence of gender, race and ethnicity on a student’s college course choice. This also involved an exploration into the lack of belonging experienced by students in college courses dominated by another gender. These experiences act as deterrents for students considering these college courses, resulting in an influence on their college course choice, as we saw in the example of low female representation in STEM-related college courses. More generally, this demonstrates the fact that there are indeed external influences on a student’s college and college course choice.

3.1.4 Theories of career & college course choice

In the previous subsections, we examined the justifications students provided for picking their college courses, their justifications for picking their college, and the external influences on their college course choice. Ultimately, these subsections attempted to provide

insights into the question: *Why do people pick their college courses?* In this subsection, we will turn our attention to academic literature and popular sentiment, and attempt to answer the question: *What college course should people study?*

Holland's theory of career choice

Holland's theory of career choice, first presented in Holland (1959), posits that individual's experience satisfaction when their personality traits match the traits of the role in their work. When talking about personality traits, we are not referring a personality model such as the "Big Five" as proposed in Goldberg (2013). Rather, Holland proposes his own six categories of personality traits present in roles of work. The personality traits are acronymised as *RIASEC*, and they are defined as:

1. **Realistic:** The doers. They typically enjoy work that involves using their hands, which include making or tinkering with physical objects. Examples of Realistic jobs include Construction Workers and Bakers.
2. **Investigative:** The thinkers. They are intellectually curious and enjoy work that involves observation, research or analysis. Examples of "Investigative" jobs include Scientists and Philosophers.
3. **Artistic:** The creators. They enjoy expressing themselves creatively and appreciate a lack of structure in solving problems. Examples of "Creative" jobs include Graphic Designers and Actors.
4. **Social:** The helpers. They typically enjoy working with and helping people, and have strong interpersonal skills. Examples and "Social" jobs include Teachers and Nurses.
5. **Enterprising:** The persuaders. They typically enjoy managing people or influencing others, and are often confident and assertive. Examples of "Enterprising" jobs include Lawyers and Managers.
6. **Conventional:** The organisers. They typically enjoy work that involves order and organisation, with strong attention to detail and adherence to rules. Examples of "Conventional" jobs include Accountants and Librarians.

These personality traits in work are alternatively defined as the RIASEC model. A visual graphic of Holland's RIASEC model can be seen in figure 3.4. Holland remarks that individuals may exhibit many of the above personality traits simultaneously, and do

not necessarily exhibit just one trait. As well as this, the traits are not simply binary and have gradations of strength - in other words, a person may demonstrate strong Investigative qualities, moderate Social qualities and weak Realistic qualities. Holland developed an identification system called “Holland Codes” that involves the first letter of each of his six traits. Holland Codes are essentially used to classify people or jobs under Holland’s proposed categories. To give some examples, a Digital Marketer would generally be classed as an “AE” Holland Code, meaning the role exhibits Artistic and Enterprising qualities, as the role involves designing campaigns to influence public perception (Enterprising) and creating visually-appealing displays (Artistic). A Surgeon would generally be classed as an “RIS” Holland Code, meaning the role exhibits Realistic, Investigative and Social qualities, as the role involves strong dexterity with hands (Realistic), deep understanding of human biology (Investigative) and strong patient communication skills (Social). Generally, a Holland Code is no longer than 3 letters.

It is worth mentioning that Holland’s proposed personality traits are nuanced and not simplistic. For instance, a biologist may demonstrate “Investigative” qualities through their fascination with human biology, whereas a sociologist may demonstrate “Investigative” qualities through their interest in subcultures. This does not imply that a biologist would be interested in subcultures, or that a sociologist would be fascinated with human biology. In other words, Holland’s personality traits manifest themselves differently in different people.

The impact of Holland’s theory on the field of Vocational Psychology cannot be overstated - according to Spokane and Cruza-Guet (2005), Holland’s theory is the most extensively researched career theory. That being said, some aspects of Holland’s theory have been challenged. For instance in Einarsdóttir et al. (2020), they argue the personality model may not appropriately fit the vocational interest structure of Icelanders. In spite of these imperfections, large bodies of research have mostly supported Holland’s personality model among high-school students, college students and working adults, according to Nauta (2010), demonstrating the theory’s robustness over time.

Holland’s theory has become ubiquitous in Guidance Counselling in Ireland. The Career Interests Inventory (CII)⁴, a quiz that provides an individual with their Holland Code, is listed by the Irish Department of Education as an acceptable career guidance test in Guidance Counselling practice, according to Department of Education (2024). In

⁴<https://teamfocus.co.uk/psychometrics/motivation/career-interests-inventory>

addition to this, the leading career guidance website in Ireland is CareersPortal⁵, with under 20 million average active recipients per month⁶. CareersPortal helps users find jobs using an Interest Profiler quiz⁷ which is largely inspired by Holland’s six personality categories, demonstrating Holland’s theory’s extensive impact across career guidance and Guidance Counselling in Ireland.

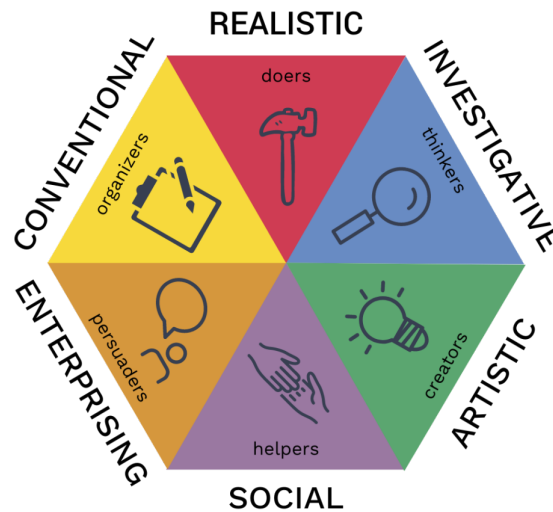


Figure 3.4: Holland’s RIASEC model. Source: ⁸

Life-Span, Life-Space Theory

Despite the evident success and utility of career fit theories’ such as Holland’s, there are limitations to these kinds of theories. Most notably, matching an individual’s traits to a job’s traits involves the individual making a decision at a particular point in time. Super (1980) argues that an individual’s career is not one static decision. Rather, Super poses that career development is a lifelong process with a series of developmental stages, in which the individual’s self-concept evolves over their lifespan. In this view, an individual’s career is the cumulative outcome of many decisions taken at different points in time. Even in the case where an individual’s studied college course is not relevant to their job - in which 23% of Irish graduates reported in Higher Education Authority (2018) - under Super’s theory, that decision is still encompassed as part of the individual’s career.

Super coined this as Life-Span, Life-Space Theory (LSLST). The “Life-Span” refers

⁵<https://careersportal.ie/>

⁶ According to <https://careersportal.ie/about-us>

⁷https://careersportal.ie/members/interests_check.php

to the lifelong developmental process of career, whereas “Life-Space” refers to the jobs and roles that occupy the individual at different stages in their career, according to the definition from Hartung (2013). In spite of the prominence of LSLST, it has faced criticism for failing to account for the dynamic careers of women, which are often interrupted by caregiving, according to Fitzgerald and Betz (1994). It is worth noting that Holland’s theory is not at odds with Super’s theory, rather Super intended to complement the established utility of Holland’s theory, according to Greenhaus and Callanan (2006).

The Passion Hypothesis

One of the most popular sentiments when it comes to career advice is to “*Follow your Passion*”. This sentiment was birthed in Bolles (1972), a self-help book for job-hunters, which sold over ten million copies⁹. The sentiment gained a surge in popularity when Steve Jobs, the co-founder of *Apple*¹⁰, famously claimed in his commencement speech at the 2005 Stanford University Graduation: “*The only way to do great work is to love what you do*”¹¹. Jobs’ speech garnered a large amount of popularity, amassing over 48 million views¹² on YouTube, demonstrating the sentiment’s widespread appreciation.

Newport (2016) coins this as the Passion Hypothesis - the idea that to find great work, you simply find out what you love and follow those interests. As appealing as “Follow your Passion” sounds, the advice has many limitations. The underlying implication of this advice is that passions are pre-existing, and neglects the idea that passions can be developed. This then prompts the question: “*Can passion be found or developed at work?*”, which is answered in O’Keefe et al. (2018). Following the definition in Dweck (2006), In O’Keefe et al.’s, experiment, the participants were broadly categorised into “fixed theorists”, who believed that personal interests are relatively fixed, and “growth theorists” who believed personal interests are developed. According to O’Keefe et al.’s findings, the fixed theorists were more likely to dampen their interests in areas outside of their existing interests, suggesting a level of narrow-mindedness for the fixed theorists. As well as this, when engaging in a new interest became difficult, the interest dropped significantly more for fixed theorists in comparison to growth theorists, suggesting that growth theorists have more endurance when encountering inevitable difficulties when pursuing their interests.

⁹As of 2016 according to: <https://shorturl.at/jiHn2>

¹⁰<https://www.apple.com/>

¹¹<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UF8uR6Z6KLc>

¹²As of March 2026.

Endorsing the Passion Hypothesis implies that one's passions are pre-existing, and fails to recognise that passions can be nurtured at work, as is similarly found in Chen et al. (2015). While the sentiment is not officially a theory according to scientific definition¹³, it is commonly given as career advice, and as a result was relevant to this discussion.

Summary of Theories of career & college course choice

In this section, we turned our attention to academic literature and popular sentiment in answering the question: *What college course should people study?* An exploration of Holland's theory of career choice was provided, a ubiquitous and transformative career choice theory. In spite of Holland's theory's established robustness in the literature, it fails to account for the dynamic, lifelong nature of careers. The work of Super nicely fits in, as Super conceptualises career in this manner under Life-Span Life-Space theory (LSLST). This theory emphasises the notion of career as a developmental process in which an individual evolves in their self-concept. Super developed LSLST to complement the growing influence of Holland's theory. We can then turn our attention away from academic literature to popular sentiment - in which an exploration into the appealing advice "Follow your passion" was given. On the whole, this section provided the reader with a solid understanding into the differing theories of career and college course choice.

3.1.5 Job & career satisfaction

In subsection 3.1.4, we turned our attention to academic literature and popular sentiment, to provide insights to the question: *What college course should people study?* In this subsection, rather than finding out what college course people should study by looking forward, we will take a look back and examine the satisfaction of individuals in their jobs and careers. The insights gleaned from examining job and career satisfaction will help us answer the above question. It is worth mentioning that jobs are distinct to careers; following the definition from Super (1980), career is the cumulative outcome of an individual's vocational decisions over their lifespan. On the other hand, a job is at a specific stage in an individual's career. While jobs are distinct to careers, we will discover that the traits of job and career satisfaction are very similar, so in this discussion, the traits of job and career satisfaction will be explored together.

Before we begin our examination on the factors of job & career satisfaction, it is worth taking some time to examine what individuals value most from their work, and a rele-

¹³Following the definition according to <https://www.fieldmuseum.org/blog/what-do-we-mean-theory-science>

vant paper for this discussion would be Harpaz (1990). In spite of the paper's age, the paper has particular relevance as it was conducted across 7 countries and 3 continents with $n=8192$. According to Harpaz' findings, the two most prominent work values were *Interesting Work* and *Salary*. These values were consistent across gender, age and nationality. As well as this, the next most prominent work values were *Colleague Relationships*, *Job Security* and *Autonomy*. With an overview of what individuals most value in their jobs, we shall now examine the literature to investigate whether these values contribute substantially towards job satisfaction. It is worth noting that some, not all, of these work values will be examined in detail for the sake of brevity.

Before we examine these work values in detail, essential to the discussion of job satisfaction is Herzberg's Two-factor theory as outlined in Herzberg (1959). Herzberg's theory posits that job satisfaction is influenced by two factors, which are coined as *Motivators* and *Hygiene Factors*. Motivators *lead* to job satisfaction, whereas Hygiene Factors *prevent* job dissatisfaction. Examples of Motivators include *Interesting Work*, *Achievement*, *Autonomy* and a sense of *Meaning*, and examples of Hygiene Factors include *Salary*, *Job Security*, *Colleague Relationships* and *Status*. A graphic of Herzberg's two-factor theory can be seen in figure 3.5. Essentially, Herzberg's theory claims that job satisfaction has different factors to job dissatisfaction. For example, an individual may be in a high-paying, respectable job with positive colleague relationships, however the individual may not derive a sense of meaning or have interest in their job. According to Herzberg's theory, the individual would not be *dissatisfied* with their job - after all, the job does tick some boxes - although the individual would not be incredibly *satisfied* with their job given the absence of Motivators.

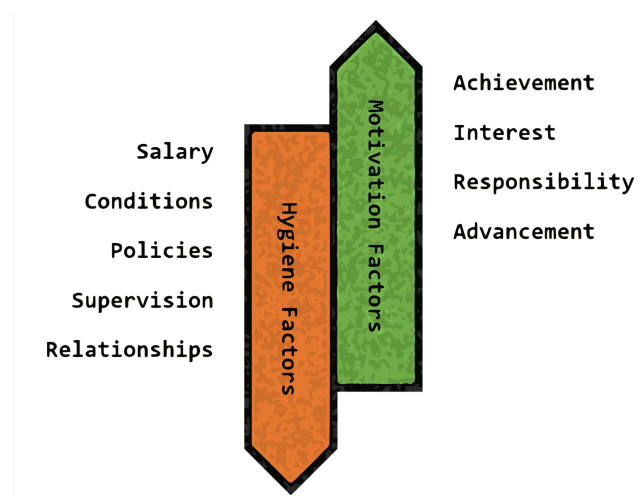


Figure 3.5: Herzberg's Two-factor theory. Source: ¹⁴

Many of Herzberg's claims are supported in the literature. For example, in Hoff et al. (2018), a meta-analysis across 105 studies, they found statistically significant positive correlation between interest-job fit and job satisfaction. Similarly, Nye et al. (2012) found that interest-job fit - or more precisely, Holland's vocational personality traits - were positive indicators for job performance and persistence in work. As mentioned previously, *Interesting Work* was one of the two most prominent work values of individuals according to Harpaz (1990), suggesting that individuals strongly value a factor that significantly contributes towards their job satisfaction. On the whole, these findings support the idea that having alignment between the individual's interests and their job's work is vital for job satisfaction.

In spite of *Salary* being one of the two most prominent work values according to Harpaz (1990), Herzberg claims that salary is a Hygiene Factor - in other words, sufficient salary in a job prevents job dissatisfaction, but it does not necessarily lead to job satisfaction. According to a meta-analysis conducted by Judge et al. (2010), they found a weak relationship between salary and job satisfaction, giving credence to Herzberg's theory with regards to salary being a Hygiene Factor (prevents job dissatisfaction) as opposed to a Motivator (provides job satisfaction). This is a particularly striking finding given that salary was one of the two most prominent work values according to Harpaz (1990).

We can further this discussion of salary in work by making reference to Ward (2024), in which they discuss a common conundrum between a meaningful job or a job with a high salary. According to their findings, individuals will consistently choose a job with a high salary and a low sense of meaning, compared to a job with a low salary and high sense of meaning. In spite of the findings of a weak relationship between salary and job satisfaction, the author would argue that prioritising salary over a sense of meaning in a job, or other work values, is understandable. According to National Youth Council of Ireland (2025), 3 of 5 Irish adults under 25 years old are considering emigrating due to the rising cost of living in Ireland, clearly demonstrating the importance of salary in jobs.

In summary, this section introduced Herzberg's two factor theory which posits that job satisfaction can be separated into Motivators, which lead to job satisfaction, and Hygiene Factors which prevent job dissatisfaction. We examined the most prominent work values of individuals, with a particular focus on Salary and Interesting work. The literature finds a significant relationship between job satisfaction and interest, although on the other hand, the literature finds a weak relationship between job satisfaction and salary.

That being said, it was argued that prioritisation of salary in jobs is understandable given the rising cost of living in Ireland.

3.1.6 Summary and synthesis of findings

This subsection will provide a brief summary of this section's key findings, and then present a synthesis of the findings.

In summary, we first examined the common justifications students provided for their college course choice, which included *interest*, *salary* and a sense of *meaning*. Secondly, we examined the common justifications students provided for their college choice, which included *prestige/status* and *location/practicality*. As well as this, students' college course choices were found to have undeniable external influences, the most notable of which are their parent's educational and financial background, gender and race/ethnicity. Understanding the background to a student's justifications and external influences are key to understanding how and why students choose their college course. As part of our exploration in the fundamentals of college course choice, there was an examination into differing theories of career and college course choice. This included a description of Holland's 6 personality traits in work, also known as the RIASEC model, a transformative theory that is ubiquitous in Irish Guidance Counselling. In addition to this, we examined the literature of job satisfaction and discussed the strong relationship between interest-fit and job satisfaction, and the weak relationship between salary and job satisfaction.

As described in this section's introduction, this section attempted to provide insights to the question: "*What college course should people study?*" As is evident from the coverage of this literature, the answer to this question, if there is one, is not straightforward. Despite this, this dissertation will attempt an attempt to answer this question by synthesising this section's findings.

So, according to this dissertation's opinions and findings, *what college course should people study?* Given the significant relationship between interest-job fit and job satisfaction, and the fact that many individuals value interesting work in their college course jobs, an individual should consider studying a college course that they either **find interesting**, or can see themselves **developing an interest in**. As well as this, given the robustness and ubiquity of Holland's theory of career choice, or the RIASEC model, an individual should consider studying a college course that aligns with their **RIASEC model**. Moreover, given the aforementioned rising cost of living in Ireland, students may

also consider college courses for their **salary** or **job prospects**. Many students expressed interest in college courses or careers that are meaningful, so a student may also consider a college course for their sense of **meaning** or **impact**. Beyond the college course, a student should also consider the actual **college** at which to study their chosen course, which may impact their decision depending on the availability of the college course at different colleges.

This is of course, a simplified answer to a very multi-faceted question, and the author would like to acknowledge that this answer serves more as a guideline, as opposed to a “one-size-fits-all” answer. In addition to this, the factors provided in this answer were deemed to be the most prominent or important factors given the reviewed literature, however, as is evident from our prior review, there are many reasons as to why a student may be satisfied with their college course choice, and this reason may be beyond the scope of the provided answer. For example, a student may choose to study a particular course primarily because they are seeking positive work/life balance.

The reader may notice that a handful of the previously discussed topics, such as gender, did not feature in this dissertation’s attempt at answering the question: *what college course should people study?* The author would argue that even if some factors, for example gender, do not feature in this dissertation’s answer attempt, it is still worth discussing the clear influence these factors have on college course choice. Having an awareness of these factors, even if they do not explicitly feature in the final answer attempt, are still useful in understanding the nature of college course choice, and having an implicit, intuitive understanding in answering the all-elusive question: *what college course should people study?*

3.2 Closely-Related Work

As outlined in section 1.1, choosing a suitable college course is a multi-faceted, difficult decision for students. The college course decision is personally confronting for students and there are a variety of external influences on their college course choice, as is evident from the examinations in subsections 3.1.1 and 3.1.3. Technologies, not limited to a Recommender System (RS), have been used to assist students in finding suitable college courses for them. In this section, we will examine the academic literature and real-world products for technologies that have assisted students in their college course decision-making process. We will start with the simplest technologies, and work our way up through more sophisticated solutions in assisting student’s with their college course choice.

3.2.1 Simple filters

CareersPortal¹⁵ and Qualifax¹⁶ are the two leading college course databases in Ireland¹⁷. The simplest technology for assisting Irish student’s in their college course selection is to use the preset filters on these websites as you search their college course database. CareersPortal allows users to filter by multiple features shown in Figure 3.6, which includes filtering by career sector (see Figure 3.7), and career interests¹⁸ (see Figure 3.8). After applying some of these filters, a user would be presented with a result, an example of which is shown in Figure 3.9.

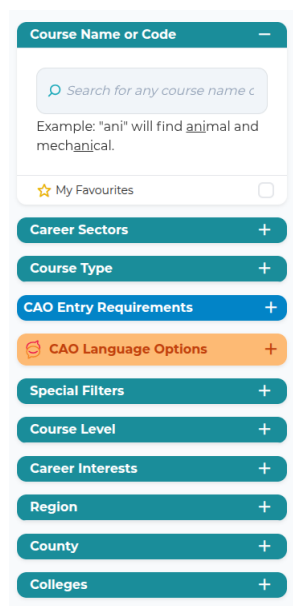


Figure 3.6: Career-Portal’s college course filters.

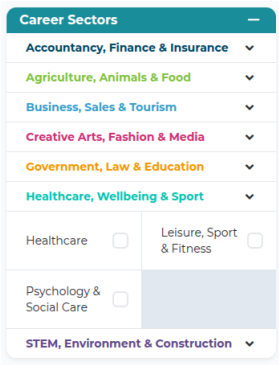


Figure 3.7: CareerPortal’s career sector filter.



Figure 3.8: CareerPortal’s career interests filter.

¹⁵<https://careersportal.ie/>
¹⁶<https://www.qualifax.ie/>
¹⁷Qualifax has over 500,000 users annually. source: <https://www.annertech.com/case-studies/qualifax-making-information-easy-irelands-learners>
¹⁸CareerPortal’s career interests are explained in Chapter 6 **TODO**

Save	Course	Course Title	College	NFQ Level	Duration	QQI Links	Points
☐	U5956 CAO	Athletic and Rehabilitation Therapy (Athlone Campus)	TUS Midlands	8	4 Years	Link	488 ▲ 4
☐	CK712 CAO	Children's and General Nursing (Integrated)	University College Cork - UCC	8	4 Years	Link	522 ▲ 11
☐	DC218 CAO	Children's and General Nursing (Integrated)	Dublin City University - DCU	8	4.5 Years	Link	509 ▲ 22
☐	DN451 CAO	Children's and General Nursing (Integrated)	University College Dublin - UCD	8	4 Years	Link	510 ▲ 15
☐	TR911 CAO	Children's and General Nursing (Integrated)	Trinity College Dublin - TCD	8	4 Years	Link	520 * ▲ 13
☐	TU868 CAO	Clinical Measurement Physiology	TU Dublin - Grangegorman	8	4 Years	Link	499 ▲ 22
☐	AU973 CAO	Clinical Measurement Physiology (Sligo Campus)	ATU Sligo	8	4 Years	Link	462 ▼ -3
☐	TR007 CAO	Clinical Speech and Language Studies	Trinity College Dublin - TCD	8	4 Years	Link	541 ▼ -12
☐	TR802 CAO	Dental Hygiene	Trinity College Dublin - TCD	7	2 Years	Link	578 # ▲ 44
☐	TR052 CAO	Dental Science	Trinity College Dublin - TCD	8	5 Years	Link	625 * ▲ 13
☐	TR803 CAO	Dental Technology	Trinity College Dublin - TCD	7	3 Years	Link	566 # * ▲ 215
☐	CK702 CAO	Dentistry	University College Cork - UCC	8	5 Years	Link	613 * ▲ 13

Figure 3.9: A sample result of what users would see after applying some filters to a course search in CareersPortal.

Qualifax operates similarly: they allow user to filter their college course database by numerous filters, including by college course category (Figure 3.10). After applying some of these filters, a user would be presented with a result as shown in Figure 3.11.

QUALIFAX

Courses About Us Information Hub Calendar News Help

Courses per page: 20 50 100
Displaying 1 - 20 of 23

Clear Filters

Course title or code

Course title or code

Search

☐ Include courses with matching keywords

Course Type

☒ Higher Education CAO

☐ PLC Post Leaving Cert

☐ Lifelong Learning

☐ Higher Education Direct Entry

☐ Postgraduate

☐ Short Courses

☐ UCAS

Course Provider

Search...

☐ ATU - Atlantic Technological University

☐ ATU - Donegal Campuses

☐ ATU - Sligo Campus

☐ MTU - Kerry Campus

Medicine

University of Galway
Galway City
CAO Points: 728

Medicine

University of Limerick
Limerick City

Medicine

Trinity College Dublin
Dublin City Centre
CAO Points: 739

Medicine - Graduate Entry

Figure 3.10: Qualifax' college course category filter.

Figure 3.11: A sample result of what users would see after applying some filters to a course search in Qualifax.

Simple filters in college course search, such as the CareersPortal and Qualifax websites, are useful as they allow students to scan a large variety of courses. However, the strength of these filters are also it's greatest weakness - the quantity of choice. Even after applying a handful of filters, for example in Figure 3.9, a user is still presented with 119 courses. This is a large quantity of courses, which may result in a phenomenon known as overchoice, coined in Toffler (1970). According to Toffler, overchoice is a paradoxical phenomenon where choosing between a large variety of options can be detrimental to decision-making processes. As a result, we find that simple filtering technologies present large quantities of college course options, however, this does not necessarily make the decision-making process easier due to the phenomenon of overchoice. Long et al. (2025) demonstrated that smaller sets of suggestions are often equally as effective as larger suggestion sets¹⁹, calling for technologies to apply *personalisation*, pruning their results and presenting more tailored college courses to the student, setting the scene for our next subsection.

3.2.2 College course quizzes

In this subsection, we will examine technologies that provide more personalisation to a user in the context of college course recommendations. More specifically, there will be a discussion on online quizzes that provide users with a more tailored, personalised list of college course recommendations. As a side note, seeing as these are real-world products, we will not have an insight into the recommendation algorithms behind these quizzes; we will only have access to their front-facing user interface.

For this discussion, we will examine the college major quizzes offered by SuperProf²⁰, Anderson University²¹ and Marquette University²². These quizzes ask the user close-ended questions, and generally the questions are tasked with discovering the student's interests in different areas of study. Examples of the kinds of questions that get asked are seen in Figures 3.12 and 3.13.

¹⁹For specificity, this research was conducted in the context of Recommender Systems, however the findings are still appropriately applied in this case.

²⁰<https://www.superprof.com/blog/college-major-quiz/>

²¹<https://anderson.edu/persona-quiz/>

²²<https://www.marquette.edu/academics/majors/choose-your-major/>

in Superprof’s results in figure 3.15, STEM is being suggested to the user, however STEM encompasses a wide range of college majors including Mathematics and Engineering - similar, but still different fields of study. While this may guide the user toward narrowing their college major choices, there is still a lack of *specificity* in the college major recommendations.

However, if one wants to go beyond broader fields of study and have more specificity in their college course recommendations, the technology is required to have knowledge of specific college courses being offered at specific colleges. This introduces a new requirement of the technology having up-to-date, accurate college course information being offered at multiple different colleges. Moreover as mentioned in chapter 2, the college admissions system and entry requirements differ by country, and clearly the Irish college system differs to the American college system that these quizzes refer to. Seeing as this dissertation focuses on Irish college course recommendations, these requirements call for a technology with a working knowledge of the Irish college courses and college system, and one that could suggest specific, personalised college courses according to the Irish college system.

The technology described above already does exist: *FindMyCollegeCourse* (FMCC)²⁴. To the best of our knowledge, this is the only online quiz that recommends Irish college courses. FMCC addresses many of the aforementioned limitations of other college major quizzes: the quiz has over 100 questions, demonstrating much more breadth in capturing student’s interests and preferences. Additionally, FMCC recommends specific Irish college courses as opposed to broad fields of study, and the college course information is up-to-date and accurately maintained - a challenge given the volume of new courses being added each year; see footnote 6. Naturally, the quiz is focused in the Irish college domain, which is also the focus of this dissertation. That being said, there are still some limitations and improvements which can be applied, although a more thorough discussion of this will be provided in section 3.3.

3.2.3 College course Recommender Systems

In Chapter 1, there was a reference to the Recommender System (RS) technology. In this subsection, we will turn our attention from real-world products, and examine the intersection of RS’s and college course recommendations in the academic literature. In this discussion, we will particularly focus on the type of RS’s being employed. A further

²⁴<https://findmycollegecourse.ie/>

discussion of other features of these RS's will be provided in section 3.3. An understanding of the common RS types, as discussed in section 2.8, will be useful in understanding this discussion. A comparison of the different RS types is best demonstrated in the Table 3.1:

Table 3.1: A comparison of the RS types used across closely-related works in literature.

Paper Reference	RS Type
Qamhie et al. (2020) ²⁵	Content-based Filtering
Ghugue et al. (2023)	Hybrid: Content-based Filtering & Collaborative Filtering
Lahoud et al. (2023)	Hybrid: Content-based Filtering & Knowledge-based Filtering
Su et al. (2021)	Collaborative Filtering

It is worth noting that in Lahoud et al. (2023), they tested a wide variety of RS types, and in their specific case, a hybrid RS with Content-based Filtering and Knowledge-Based Filtering yielded the best college course recommendations. That being said, as is clear from table 3.1, there is no common consensus on the most optimal RS type for the problem of college course recommendations, suggesting that a solution to this problem may adopt many of the approaches above.

3.3 Research Gap

In this section, we will synthesise our background knowledge of college course choice fundamentals, gathered in section 3.1, with our knowledge of closely-related work as explored in section 3.2, in order to clearly define a research gap. To help us with this, tables 3.2 and 3.3 define different features of the closely-related work referenced in section 3.2:

²⁵ *Note:* this paper recommends engineering fields of study as opposed to college courses, however the paper is arguably still relevant

Table 3.2: Comparing features of all examined Closely-related work (Part 1)

Name	# Questions	# Results	Recommendation Type
<i>Superprof</i>	10	3	General area of study
<i>Anderson Uni</i>	25	50	College major
<i>Marquette Uni</i>	10	30	College major
<i>FMCC</i>	~150	200	Irish college course
<i>Qamhieh et al. (2020)</i>	125	7	Engineering course
<i>Ghuge et al. (2023)</i>	6	5	College major
<i>Lahoud et al. (2023)</i>	6	5	Lebanese college course
<i>Su et al. (2021)</i>	90	5	Taiwanese college course

Explanation of columns:

Questions: the number of questions asked to the user prior to receiving their college course recommendations.

Results: The number of college course recommendations the user receives.

Recommendation Type: the type of college course recommendation the user receives.

Table 3.3: Comparing features of all examined Closely-related work (Part 2)

Name	Can filter results by college?	Profiled User Information
<i>Superprof</i>	X	Academic interests
<i>Anderson Uni</i>	X ²⁶	Academic interests
<i>Marquette Uni</i>	X ²⁷	Academic interests
<i>FMCC</i>	X ²⁸	Academic interests
<i>Qamhieh et al. (2020)</i>	X	Hobbies, Grades, MBTI ²⁹
<i>Ghuge et al. (2023)</i>	X	Hobbies, Grades
<i>Lahoud et al. (2023)</i>	✓	Hobbies, Gender, Academic interests
<i>Su et al. (2021)</i>	X ³⁰	RIASEC personality model

Explanation of columns:

Can filter results by college? is it possible for the user to specifically receive college course recommendations from colleges of their choice?

Profile User Information: What information is the system profiling off the user in order to make personalised college course recommendations?

With a clearer overview of the differing features of all the examined Closely-related work, we can now clearly define our research gap. By examining table 3.3 above, we can observe that no closely-related works have applied the combination of *Holland's RIASEC model* and *Academic Interests*. Given the ubiquity and robustness of Holland's RIASEC model, as described in subsection 3.1.4, and the statistically significant positive correlation between interests and job satisfaction, as described in subsection 3.1.5, we are presented with an exciting opportunity to merge Holland's RIASEC model and the user's academic interests in providing personalised college course recommendations. It is worth noting that a more elaborate justification of related design decisions will be provided in section 5.2.

In addition to this, when we examine Table 3.2, few of the examined closely-related works recommend specific college courses in a particular country - with just one in Ireland (FMCC). The Irish college admissions system presents an interesting use-case for this problem for many reasons. Firstly, all college applications go through the CAO³¹, which is a centralised system, as opposed to other countries, such as the USA, where students must apply to colleges directly. Secondly, the CAO requires the student to create a ranked list of their preferred college courses. Seeing as RS's provide their users with ranked lists of items, it is quite appropriate to apply an RS to the domain of Irish college course recommendations. As a result, the Irish CAO system presents an interesting case study for research to be conducted in the context of a College Course RS problem.

As we discovered in subsection 3.1.2, the choice of college is an important factor in a student's college course decision-making process. Only one (Lahoud et al. (2023)) of the examined closely-related works above allow users to filter their college course recommendation results by specific colleges. Moreover in Ireland, there is no work that allows a user to be recommended college courses for specific colleges³². As a result, this research seeks to allow users to filter their college course recommendations by specific colleges, a research gap in the context of Irish college course RS's.

We can now succinctly and clearly define our research gap: a college course RS applied

²⁶The only college majors recommended are ones offered from Anderson University.

²⁷The only college majors recommended are ones offered from Marquette University.

²⁸You can filter your colleges by region, for example just the colleges in Dublin, Munster, etc.

²⁹Myer-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI); a personality test developed in Myers et al. (1962).

³⁰The only college majors recommended are ones offered from Cheng Shiu University, Taiwan.

³¹Central Applications Office; see section 2.3 for background reading regarding the CAO.

³²As mentioned in table 3.3, FMCC allows users to filter their colleges by *region*, but not specific colleges.

to the **Irish context**, utilising a user's **RIASEC model** and **Academic interests**, allowing the user to filter their college course recommendations by **specific colleges**. This ultimately describes this dissertation's unique contribution to the literature.

3.4 Chapter Summary

This chapter started with an investigation into the fundamentals of college course choice. More broadly, the section explored different answers to the all-elusive question: “*What college course should people study?*” There are a multitude of factors in this decision, and this dissertation provided it's own answer to the question. However, the author wishes to stress that the answer is by no means exhaustive, and should instead be taken as a guideline.

Investigating this question provided us the necessary background knowledge to analyse the closely-related works in the space of college course recommendations. This work was performed for two main reasons: firstly, to develop an awareness of the surrounding literature, and secondly, to clearly define the research gap this dissertation addresses. With an enhanced knowledge of the background literature of this problem, we can now move on to the next chapters.

Chapter 4

Initial Prototypes

As part of this research, a significant portion of time was dedicated towards a particular approach in solving this dissertation’s research question. Arguably, it is worth dedicating time to detailing this failed approach, as it involves the use of popular datasets that others may use in solving similar problems to this dissertation. This chapter will describe the motivations behind the chosen approach, the implementation details, and then evaluate the results and describe why the experiment yielded unsatisfactory results.

4.1 Design Motivation

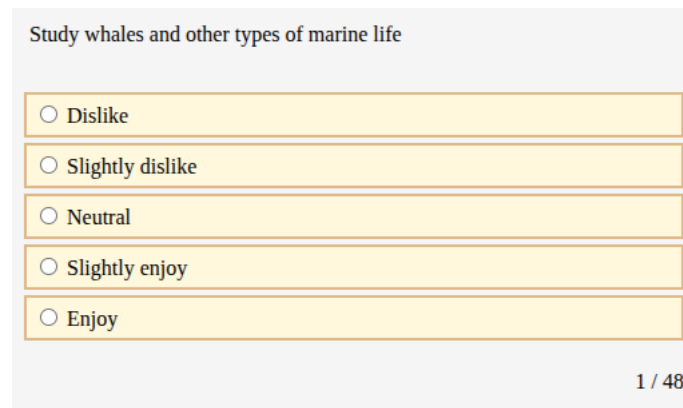
In this section, we will describe the motivation behind this approach. If we recall the Research Question as outlined in section 1.2, we are seeking to design an RS that *assists* a user’s exploration into college courses by providing with them **relevant**, **diverse** and **serendipitous** recommendations. Among the three types of RS’s described in section 2.8, *Collaborative Filtering* (CF) is more likely to provide **serendipitous** recommendations, according to Aggarwal et al. (2016). This is because CF does not solely rely on what the user likes, rather it leverages the data of what *other* similar users also liked, increasing the likelihood of more surprising, but relevant recommendations, i.e. serendipity. As also described in section 3.3, serendipity is the gold standard of RS’s, and it would be incredibly useful in answering our Research Question by assisting the user in their exploration of college courses. As a result, this chapter will explore a CF approach as it potentially provides more serendipitous recommendations.

It is worth mentioning that for the sake of brevity, this chapter will not feature a vivid description of the different strategies attempted to improve model performance. Instead, we will focus on our best attempt in solving this problem through the CF approach.

4.2 Datasets and initial challenges

In section 3.3, we identified a research gap by leveraging a user’s RIASEC model and Academic Interests to provide personalised college course recommendations. However, in order to design a CF RS in this context, we need to find datasets with **other users’ college choice**, and either their Academic Interests or RIASEC model. To the best of our knowledge, this kind of data is not available in the Irish context. As a result, we explored similar datasets outside of the Irish context.

A promising dataset in this context was published by OpenPsychometrics¹ with data on over 140,000 individuals. In this dataset, which will be referred to as the ‘RIASEC dataset’, feature the results of a 48-question quiz which determined the user’s RIASEC model. This quiz asked the user how much they enjoyed certain activities on a 5-point Likert scale, i.e. 1 implied they dislike the activity, and a 5 implied they would enjoy the activity. An example of a question is given in figure 4.1. As part of the quiz, the user was asked to provide their college major, which is crucial information in our context. After some initial data cleaning, we were left with over 70,000 user’s RIASEC quiz results and their college majors. This kind of data would be essential in designing a CF RS.



Study whales and other types of marine life

☐ Dislike

☐ Slightly dislike

☐ Neutral

☐ Slightly enjoy

☐ Enjoy

1 / 48

Figure 4.1: An example of a question given on the OpenPsychometrics RIASEC quiz.

However, as described in subsection 3.3, this dissertation seeks to design an RS that recommends specific Irish college courses, as opposed to general areas of study. The RIASEC dataset has been answered by users from all over the world, particularly from the USA. As a result, there is a challenge in mapping the college majors that users provided in the RIASEC dataset, to specific Irish college courses. Moreover, new Irish college courses are being created each year², compounding the difficulty of this problem.

¹https://openpsychometrics.org/_rawdata/

²See footnote 6

4.3 Solution to introduced problems

As a solution to the problem of specificity provided above, we can create more general categories of related college courses. For example, we can group college majors/courses such as Medicine, Nursing and Occupational Therapy under a “healthcare” category. The college majors in the RIASEC dataset can be placed into these categories, and the college courses in the Irish college course dataset can also be placed into these categories. Admittedly, a disadvantage of this solution is a loss of nuance that would occur in the mapping. In other words, specific traits of particular college majors will get lost as they are combined into a more general category with other college majors.

We now need to find a dataset with college majors and associated college major categories. A popular dataset on college majors in the USA³ was most appropriately applied to this problem. This dataset, which will be referred to as the ‘college major dataset’, initially featured 174 college majors and categorised each college major under 15 categories. However, in its initial form, this college major dataset failed to capture many of the college majors provided in the RIASEC dataset. In addition to this, many of the college major categories were too broad, and were then split up into different college major categories. As a result, this college major dataset underwent significant manual revisions, and the final form of this dataset is provided in **TODO - appendix!**. After these significant manual revisions, the college major dataset featured over 200 college majors with 16 categories.

We now have a college major dataset with over 200 college majors and 16 associated college major categories, and a RIASEC dataset with over 70,000 user’s college majors and the results of their RIASEC quiz. Using a pre-processing script as given in **TODO - appendix!**, we can categorise each of the ~70,000 users in the RIASEC dataset into one of 16 college major categories as provided in the college major dataset. This augmented dataset will be instrumental in training a Machine Learning model to predict a user’s college major category from the results of this RIASEC quiz, which will be explored in the next section.

³<https://github.com/fivethirtyeight/data/tree/master/college-majors>

4.4 Machine Learning model selection

From the work in the last section, we now have a dataset with over 70,000 user's RIASEC quiz results, and their college major category. This can be reconceptualised in the context of a Machine Learning (ML) problem: we have 48 input features, and 1 output variable. In this case, each input feature is a rating from 1–5, indicating the user's enjoyment towards a particular task, and the output is one of 16 college major categories.

Many different ML models were trained on this data, and they were tested on unseen data to gather evaluation metrics, in particular: top-1 and top-3 accuracy. The ML model with the best top-1 and top-3 accuracy was the Histogram-based Gradient Boosting Classifier (HGBC), with its implementation details given in **todo - appendix!**. This implementation of a HGBC achieved a top-1 accuracy of **0.319**, and a top-3 accuracy of **0.606**. In other words for the unseen test set, this HGBC implementation predicted the user's college major category correctly in 31.9% of cases (top-1 accuracy), and in 60.6% of cases, the model predicted the user's college major category correctly in its first 3 predictions (top-3 accuracy). Seeing as this implementation of the HGBC model had the best performance metrics, we can evaluate its performance further in the next section.

4.5 Model Evaluation

In this section we will take a closer look in evaluating the chosen HGBC model's performance. In figure 4.2 below, we can observe the Confusion Matrix of the chosen model, showcasing the recall scores.

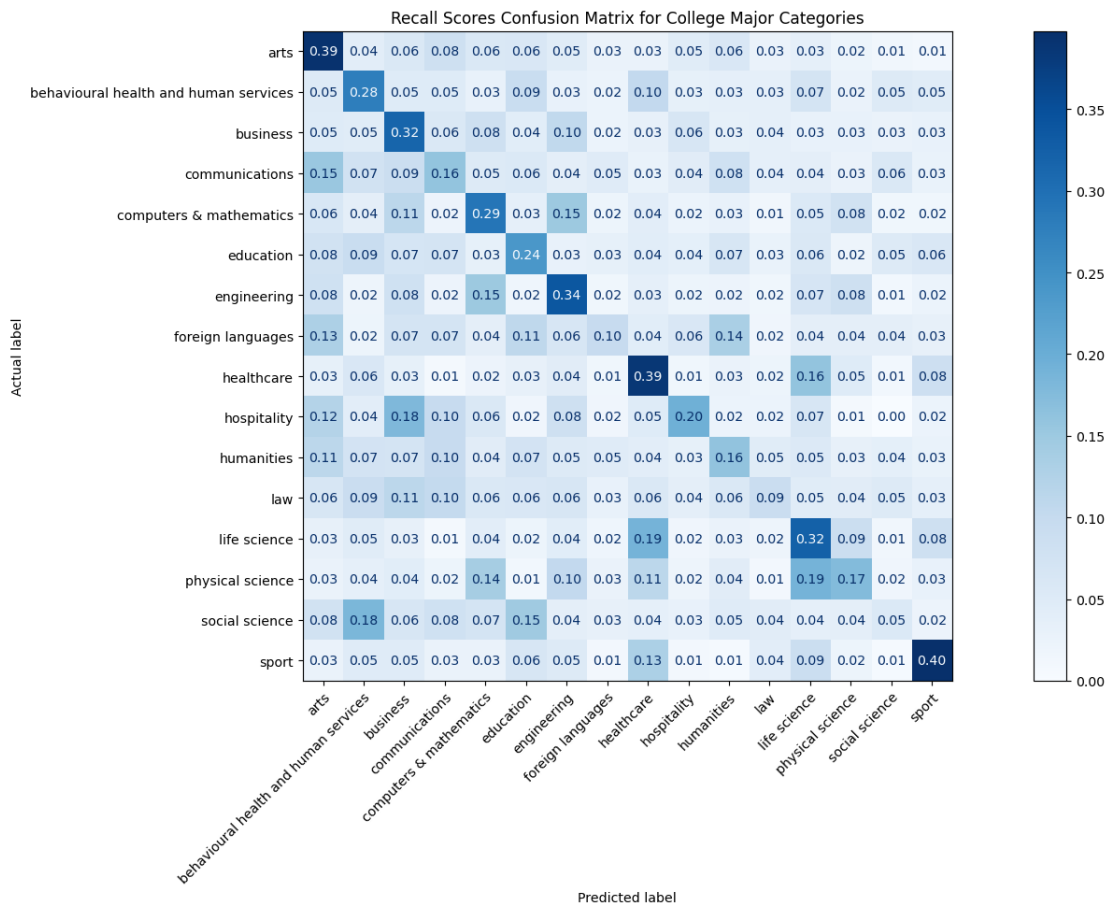


Figure 4.2: A Confusion Matrix for Recall scores on the HGBC model.

To take one example, we can observe that the model achieved a recall score of 0.4 for the “sports” college major category, meaning that of all the users with “sports” as their college major category, the model correctly predicted “sports” for these users 40% of the time. Relatively speaking, we can see that this recall score of 0.4 is the highest performing recall score out of all the other college major categories. In particular, we can see the model struggling with some college major categories, such as “foreign languages” with a recall score of 0.1, and “social science” with a score of 0.05, meaning that the model correctly predicts the user’s college major category 10% and 5% of the time respectively.

Honestly speaking, the performance of this model was disappointing as demonstrated through the low recall scores referenced above. Many different ML models with differing configurations were applied to the problem, failing to provide any improvements to this HGBC implementation. As well as this, the college major dataset underwent significant manual revisions - adding new college majors and splitting up different college major categories, all failed attempts to improve the model’s performance.

4.6 Limitations of the approach

In the previous section, we established the poor performance of this model in predicting the user’s college major category given the results of a 48-question RIASEC quiz. In this section, we will provide more insights as to *why* the model with these popular datasets performed poorly.

In the context of predicting a user’s college major, the primary limitation of the chosen RIASEC dataset is the lack of coverage by the questions. In other words, the 48 questions do not adequately cover many areas of study, which we believe is the primary reason behind the poor performance behind the model. For example, if we revisit figure 4.2, we can observe very poor model performance on the “foreign languages” category, with a recall score of 0.1. This is simply because there are no questions in the RIASEC dataset that are explicitly related to languages or linguistics. To provide another example, we can observe very poor recall scores for the “law” category, most likely because there are no questions in the quiz that are explicitly related to law or government. Without this data, the model finds it very difficult to discern if a user is studying in the “foreign languages” or “law” categories, explaining the model’s poor performance on these categories.

Due to this limitation, we found this dataset and subsequent approach to be inadequate in solving our problem, due to the poor recall scores as reported in figure 4.2. In spite of many efforts to improve the model’s performance through significant manual revisions to the college major dataset, and testing multiple different ML models and configurations, the performance of the model was still deemed unsatisfactory.

4.7 Chapter Summary

In this chapter, we explored an approach to solving this dissertation’s research question by utilising a very popular RIASEC dataset. There was a description of the motivation in using this dataset, followed by an explanation of the various data engineering performed on both datasets in order to make it more suitable for a traditional ML problem. We evaluated the performance of the best performing model, and found the results to be unsatisfactory. Ultimately, we believe the unsatisfactory results to be a result of the poor coverage of the 48 questions on many different fields of study. As a result, we believe that a dataset such as this may not be particularly useful in solving a problem similar to the one addressed in this dissertation. That being said, we felt it was worth writing about our inadequate solutions in this chapter, firstly because of the popularity of this dataset,

and secondly to add a useful contribution to the literature. In the next chapter, we will explore a more successful approach in solving this problem.

Chapter 5

Design

todo chap intro

talk about good qualities of an RS? actually maybe not idk

5.1 Interviews with Guidance Counsellors

As part of this research, interviews were conducted with two professional Guidance Counsellors (GC's) in Ireland, with decades of experience between them. The main purpose of these interviews was to gain a deeper understanding of the GC process. In particular, we were curious as to what information a GC asks a student in order to make college course recommendations. Naturally, this exploration is relevant as we will be designing an RS that provides personalised college course recommendations. This section will feature some insights gleaned from both interviews, and they will inspire the final design of this dissertation's Recommender System.

5.1.1 Academic Interests

i talk about academic interest quiz, but it has no context - might need to add context about quiz/profiling info

In section 3.3, we identified a research gap by utilising a user's RIASEC model and Academic interests to provide personalised college course recommendations. Both GC's were asked about the relevance of Academic Interests in making college course recommendations. Both GC's were in agreement that Academic Interests are incredibly useful in providing personalised college course recommendations, which is promising to hear as this is one side to our research gap as mentioned previously.

As part of their GC process, they generally ask their students about their favourite and least favourite subjects. While this information is evidently useful, we can recall the information about Leaving Certificate (LC) subjects in 2.1. In their last years of secondary school, students take at least 6 LC subjects. Arguably, if we only rely on a student's LC subjects as a source for information for Academic Interests, we may miss out on a student's Academic Interests outside of the LC subjects they take. For example, a student may demonstrate strong interest in History, but if they do not study LC History, we may miss out on this information.

To account for this, we may consider an “Academic Interests Quiz” with much broader coverage across all areas of study, meaning that the RS can capture this information, even in the event where the student did not happen to study the subject in secondary school.

5.1.2 The RIASEC Model

In section 3.3, we identified a research gap by utilising a user's RIASEC model and Academic interests to provide personalised college course recommendations. In spite of the ubiquity and robustness of the RIASEC model as established in section 3.1.4, we asked both GC's for their opinion on the RIASEC model. One of the GC's found the RIASEC model to be a limiting snapshot of a person, and personally does not place a lot of value on it.

In all honesty, we are in agreement that the RIASEC model does provide a limited snapshot of the user. As mentioned in section 3.1.4, the RIASEC traits are nuanced. For example, a biologist and philosopher may both demonstrate “Investigative” qualities, however they may not be interested in each other's field. As a result, we can agree that a user's RIASEC model is a limited snapshot of them *in isolation*. However, we can pair a user's RIASEC model with other pieces of information about the user - in our case, that would be their Academic Interests.

This then begs the question: “*If a RIASEC model is redundant without Academic Interests, is the RIASEC model really useful?*” We would argue that a user's RIASEC model is useful *in conjunction* with Academic Interests. For example, suppose a student demonstrates an interest in Computers as an Academic Interest. With the user's RIASEC model, we can make more informed recommendations. For example, if the user demonstrates a high “Realistic” trait, they may be suited for more ‘hands-on’ college courses relating to Computers, such as Computer Engineering. On the other hand, if

the user demonstrates a high “Enterprising” trait, they may be more suited for a college course like Computer Science with Business, as the “Enterprising” trait is common in Business studies. This additional information may appear redundant, however, we would argue this provides more context to the RS, allowing the RS to potentially provide more **serendipitous** recommendations.

5.1.3 Hobbies

Note: In this context, ‘Hobbies’ is being used as an umbrella term for Hobbies, Extracurriculars and Personal Interests.

Both GC’s were asked about the relevance of hobbies in their GC process, and whether they consider the information as redundant or relevant to the college course decision-making process. Both GC’s agreed that hobbies can be useful in suggesting potential college courses to their students. For example, a student that loves watching History documentaries may be suggested to study History.

While we agree that information regarding hobbies can be useful in suggesting relevant college courses to a student, we would argue that a lot of this information could be captured under an ‘Academic Interests Quiz’ with a lot of coverage. Continuing our example, a student that loves history documentaries would likely respond positively to questions relating to the ‘Humanities’ Academic Interest, which could lead to a recommendation for History anyway. In other words, with an Academic Interest quiz with good coverage, information about a user’s hobbies may be redundant in the context of college course recommendations.

5.1.4 The potential role of an RS in Guidance Counselling

Both GC’s were made aware of the research question of this dissertation, and were asked to provide their honest evaluation of how a technology, such as an RS, could fit into the GC process.

One of the GC’s remarked that their process is very instinctive and intuitive, and their meetings do not often follow a rigid structure. In most cases, the process begins by asking the student about their LC subjects, and then the discussion continues from there. As is evident from our investigations in Chapter 3, the college course decision-making process is incredibly nuanced and personally confronting. This gives credence to the human di-

mension to Guidance Counselling, a profession that requires empathy and understanding on a human level. This is incredibly challenging to replace with a technology, and the author and both GC's agreed that a technology, such as an RS, should not be designed to replace the crucial role of a GC, but rather to *complement* the GC's process, allowing the GC to shift their priorities towards the more human, nuanced parts of the college course decision-making process.

As well as this, both GC's remarked that Irish Guidance Counselling is moving from career guidance more towards personal counselling, which corresponds with the discussion in section 1.1. These changing priorities signal a potential utility in a technology, such as a college course RS, that may assist their student's in their college course decision-making process.

During one of the interviews, there was a discussion on the value of diversity in recommendations. Interestingly, one of the GC's remarked that diversity in recommendations is incredibly valuable, and that is something they integrate into their GC process. The GC claimed that they like to "challenge" their students with different recommendations, as it helps develop the student's concepts about the college courses they would consider studying. These insights are incredibly valuable, as it supports the idea that **diverse** recommendations can help answer our Research Question, which is to assist Irish students in exploring college courses they would consider studying.

todo - summarise interviews?

5.2 User Information to Profile

It would not be possible for a GC to provide a student with relevant college course recommendations if the GC knows nothing about the student. The GC must first ask the student some questions in order to gain some understanding, which would then fuel their college course suggestions. This is true for humans, but the same applies for technologies such as an RS. Naturally, the next question to ask is: *"what information does the RS profile off a user in order to provide personalised college course recommendations?"* This section will provide an answer to this question.

In the case of Guidance Counselling, the two interviewed GC's asked about a student's favourite subjects, which can be more broadly categorised as **Academic Interests**, and asked about the student's **hobbies**. However, it is worth noting that the GC process is a lot less structured and adapts to the conversation that ensues.

We can turn our attention from Guidance Counselling to our attempt in answer the question: *What college course should I study?*, as given in 3.1.6. Our answer involved factoring in a student's:

- **Academic Interests.**
- **RIASEC Model.**
- Desire for **salary** or **job prospects** after graduation.
- Desire for **meaningful** work.

As admitted in section 3.1.6, these factors are by no means exhaustive when it comes to college course choice. Furthermore, in section 3.2, we examined what information other closely-related works profile off users in order to provide personalised college course recommendations. By referencing table 3.3, we can see that these closely-related works profiled a student's:

- Academic Interests.
- RIASEC Model.
- Hobbies
- Grades.
- Gender.

Naturally, we are presented with many different categories of information to profile off a user, and now the task is to identify which categories are relevant in the context of a college course RS. In section 3.3, we justified profiling a user's **RIASEC Model** and **Academic Interests** in order to provide personalised college course recommendations. However, from above we can clearly see there are more potential pieces of information to profile off a user. In the next subsections, we will examine each of the different categories of information, and discuss if the information is relevant in the context of college course recommendations.

5.2.1 Hobbies and Grades

Given our justifications in subsection 5.1.3, we can disregard *Hobbies* as information to profile off a user. We may also disregard *Grades* because a user’s LC subjects provides a limited snapshot of their interests and aptitudes, and we may also cover this information more broadly as part of *Academic Interests*, as explained in subsection 5.1.1.

5.2.2 Salary and Job Prospects

As described above, a user’s desire for *salary* or *job prospects* after graduation would be relevant information in the context of college course recommendations. However, to the best of our knowledge, data on the mean salary or employment rate of graduates from each college course in Ireland is unavailable. As a result, it would be very challenging to effectively integrate this information into our RS. We could potentially gather data on the mean salary or employment rates of more general college course categories, for example college courses under healthcare. However, this information would be too generalised and lack nuance. Continuing our example of healthcare, the mean salaries differ greatly between different healthcare roles upon graduation. For instance, the mean salary of Medicine graduates is over €26,000 compared to Physiotherapy graduates¹. This is quite a sizable difference, even though the college courses are both grouped under the same “healthcare” category. As a result, we do not consider this approach feasible given the lack of nuance and accuracy, and so we can disregard a user’s desire for *salary* or *job prospects* in the context of our RS.

5.2.3 Meaning

As also described above, a user’s desire for *meaningful* work would be relevant information to profile off a user in the context of a college course RS. However, we believe this is challenging to work with for two main reasons. Firstly, this information is difficult to translate to something computational. For example, we could consider creating some sort of ‘meaning’ score for each college course. However, it would be challenging to meaningfully quantify this value for a college course. This challenge is compounded further for the second reason: the meaning of a college course is largely dependent on what the student does with their degree after graduation. To give an example, suppose two students graduate from Pharmaceutical Science, and one works in a large corporation

¹Data from 2023: <https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-heo/highereducationoutcomeshealthgraduates2023/employmentandearnings/>

completing work they find meaningless, and the other student dedicates their life's work to researching cutting-edge drug discovery. Both students graduate from the same college course, and have vastly different senses of meaning in their related jobs after graduation. As a result, we can disregard a user's desire for *meaning* in the context of college course recommendations, because the information is difficult to quantify, and largely depends on what the student does with their degree.

5.2.4 Gender, Race/Ethnicity and Parent's Educational/Financial Background

A user's *gender* is a piece of information profiled in some of the closely-related works. We can also extend this discussion to include a user's *race/ethnicity* and *parent's educational/financial background*, seeing as these were all external influences discussed in subsection 3.1.3. As is clearly evident from our investigations, an individual's gender, race/ethnicity and parent's educational/financial background are strong influences on an individual's college course choice. As a result, it could be reasonable to consider profiling these pieces of information off a user for the purpose of college course recommendations.

However, we would argue that these pieces of information should not be considered in the context of a college course RS. For example, by factoring in a user's gender, the RS would not only reinforce stereotypes surrounding gender, but it may also obscure the college course recommendation algorithm. To give an example, suppose that a male demonstrates interest in pre-school teacher education, which is 97% female-dominated according to Higher Education Authority (2024a). An RS algorithm may deem this course unfit for the user solely on the basis on gender, reinforcing the gender norms and stereotypes surrounding this particular course. As a result, we would argue that external influences such as *gender*, *race/ethnicity* and *parent's educational/financial background* would not be relevant in the context of college course recommendations, due to their implications.

In spite of our above efforts to unbiased the RS, it is worth remembering that a human, with all their biases and limitations, will interact with the RS, meaning that the element of bias is still unavoidably present in the RS. In this context, it is worth mentioning the work of Wang et al. (2022), in which they compared the results of biased and unbiased career recommendation algorithms. According to their findings, the users actually preferred the biased career recommendations over the unbiased recommendations. On the surface this

may appear surprising, however when we consider our investigations in subsection 3.1.3, we can recall that these factors are large influences on an individual's college course choice.

In addition to this, to the best of our knowledge, data about *race/ethnicity* and *parent's educational/financial background* are not available for each college course in Ireland, posing a challenge for integrating this effectively into a college course RS. In spite of Wang et al.'s findings, we would disregard *gender*, *race/ethnicity* and *parent's educational/financial background* in the context of college course recommendations, due to its aforementioned implications and reinforcement of stereotypes.

5.2.5 LC points, NFQ Levels and Colleges

As explained in subsection 2.4.1, a user's Leaving Cert (LC) points is an influential entry requirement to college courses in Ireland. In addition to this, Irish students may have preferences for particular types of NFQ Levels in the context of college courses. We can recall that **relevance** is an important quality of an effective RS, as described in section 1.2. For instance, it would not be useful suggesting a course that is 500 LC points to a user that is expected to receive 300 LC points. Thus, profiling a user's expected LC points and their NFQ Level preferences would provide more **relevant** college course recommendations, which better answers our Research Question, which is to assist the Irish student in exploring their college course choices.

As is evident from our discussion in subsection 3.1.2, a student has a variety of justifications for choosing their college, which is a separate decision to choosing their college course. In light of this, we should also profile the user's **preferences towards colleges**, in order to provide them with more relevant college course recommendations.

5.2.6 Section Summary

In order to provide personalised and relevant college course recommendations to a user, we must profile some information off the user. In this section, we examined the different factors we could profile off a user in the context of college course recommendations. We justified the profiling of a user's **RIASEC model**, **Academic Interests**, **Expected LC points**, **NFQ Level** and **College preferences**, in order to assist us in providing **relevant**, **diverse** and **serendipitous** college course recommendations to the user, all qualities of an effective RS as described in section 1.2. In addition to this, we justified disregarding a user's hobbies, grades, gender, race/ethnicity, parent's educational/financial

background, and their desire for salary, job prospects and meaningful work in the context of college course recommendations.

Chapter 6

Implementation

6.1 Overview of the Solution

The code in listing ?? is a demonstration how to include a file with code into the template.

6.2 Component One

The code in listing 1 is a demonstration how to include code in the template.

```
x = 1
if x == 1:
    # indented four spaces
    print("x is 1.")
```

Listing 6.1: Second Lengthy caption

Table 6.1: Example user vector representation

RIASEC							Academic Interests					
Realistic	Investigative	Artistic	Social	Enterprising	Conventional	Expected LC Points	Agriculture	...	Computers	...	Sport	Welfare
0.1	0.95	0.1	0.65	0.3	0.4	0.9	0.05	...	0.95	...	0.1	0.1

user = [0.1, 0.95, 0.1, 0.65, 0.3, 0.4, 0.9, 0.05, ..., 0.95, ..., 0.1, 0.1]

Table 6.2: Example college course vector representation

RIASEC							Academic Interests						
Realistic	Investigative	Artistic	Social	Enterprising	Conventional	LC Points	Agriculture	...	Healthcare	Life Science	...	Sport	Welfare
1.0	1.0	0.0	1.0	0.0	0.0	1.0	0.0	...	1.0	1.0	...	0.0	0.0

dentistryCollegeCourse = [1.0, 1.0, 0.0, 1.0, 0.0, 0.0, 1.0, 0.0, ..., 1.0, 1.0, ..., 0.0, 0.0]

$$\text{cosineSimilarity}(A, B) = \frac{A \cdot B}{\|A\| \|B\|}$$

6.3 Summary

Every chapter aside from the first and last chapter should conclude with a summary.

Chapter 7

Experiment Methodology

Chapter 8

Evaluation

The Evaluation chapter should present a comparison of the work that forms the basis of the dissertation and existing work. At a higher level, it should demonstrate an awareness of the relationship of the dissertation work to the research area that it is based in.

8.1 Experiments

In the case where experiments have been carried out, the experimental setup and the values that were defined for the variables need to be presented in a table e.g.

	Precision	Recall	F1 Score	Novelty	Serendipity
Actual	0.47	0.7	0.55	0.91	0.39
Baseline	0.22	0.43	0.28	0.97	0.2

Table 8.1: Objective Metrics

Metric	p-value (t-test/Wilcoxon)	Cohen's effect
Diversity	0.5826	0.1
Trust	0.000	1.19
Precision	0.000	1.34
Recall	0.000	1.12
F1 Score	0.000	1.31
Novelty	0.000	-1.0
Serendipity	0.000	1.11

Table 8.2: Statistical Significances

	Diversity	Trust
Actual	3.9	4.15
Baseline	3.7	2.35

Table 8.3: User-Perceived Metrics

Table 8.4: Comparing features of all examined Closely-related work (Part 2)

Name	Profiled User Information
<i>Superprof</i>	Academic interests
<i>Anderson Uni</i>	Academic interests
<i>Marquette Uni</i>	Academic interests
<i>FMCC</i>	Academic interests
<i>Qamhie et al. (2020)</i>	Hobbies, Grades, MBTI ¹
<i>Ghuge et al. (2023)</i>	Hobbies, Grades
<i>Lahoud et al. (2023)</i>	Hobbies, Gender, Academic interests
<i>Su et al. (2021)</i>	RIASEC personality model

Explanation of columns:

Can filter results by college? is it possible for the user to specifically receive college course recommendations from colleges of their choice?

Profile User Information: What information is the system profiling off the user in order to make personalised college course recommendations?

8.2 Results

Figures that present results such as figure ?? need to display descriptions of the axes, the units and scales of the measurements, statistical values, etc. Where measurements were taken from experiments, error bars or confidence intervals need to be provided to give the reader an indication of the spread of the measurements.

¹Myer-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI); a personality test developed in Myers et al. (1962).

8.3 Summary

Every chapter aside from the first and last chapter should conclude with a summary that presents the outcome of the chapter in a short, accessible form.

Chapter 9

Conclusions & Future Work

This chapter should summarize the work presented in the dissertation and discuss the conclusions that can be drawn from the work and the results presented in chapter 8.

It is worth noting that there are no intentions behind this RS to replace the vocational support role of a GC. Choosing a college course is a difficult and personally confronting decision, and as mentioned in Institute of Guidance Counsellors (2016), GC's are trained to additionally support a student's social and personal needs, allowing the GC to provide a student with empathetic and human-centered support - an aspect that a traditional RS would fail to effectively convey.

Furthermore, there are no intentions behind this RS to entirely replace the student's college course decision-making process. As we will discover in Chapter 3, the decision of a college course is incredibly nuanced. It is the author's opinion that no system can or should make that decision entirely for an individual. The intention behind this RS is to *complement*, rather than replace, the student's college course decision-making process, assisting the student in exploring a variety of career paths that may be relevant to them.

9.1 Future Work

The section may present a list of items that were beyond the scope of the dissertation.

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Appendix

College Major Dataset

Preprocessing script for college major classification

Histogram Gradient Boosting Classifier Implementation

```
hist_gradient_boosting_machines_model  
    = HistGradientBoostingClassifier(  
        class_weight='balanced',  
        l2_regularization=1.0  
    )
```

Listing 1: Second Lengthy caption